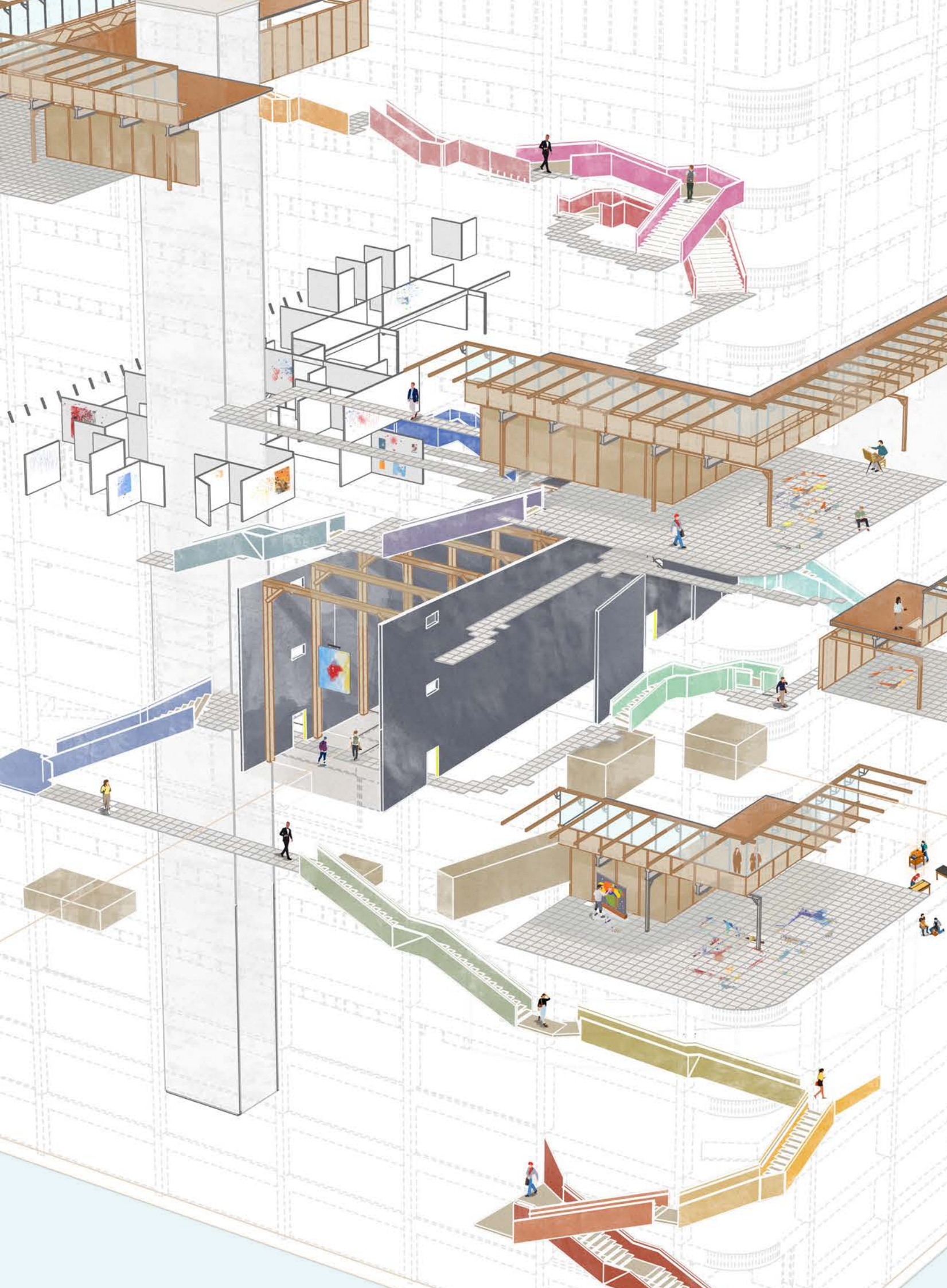




PORTFOLIO

Viola Pica

2020-2026



THE UNLIKELY TENANT

MA Thesis Project

superReuse 25-26

The MANIFESTO

My project transforms 33 Canada Square into a civic interior that reclaims a corporate environment and gives new pockets of space to artists, makers, and office workers alike. It works not only with an existing building, but with an existing community, bringing together two worlds that rarely meet. In the context of Canary Wharf, where office spaces are already becoming redundant, this becomes a way of questioning how these environments can be reused and reimaged.

My project is a manifesto, a playground in which I can test a new form of mixed use that goes against preset societal limits regarding who

creates, who works, and where these activities belong.

By inserting processes of craft in a highly polished business context, it breaks down the facelessness of the grid and introduces a chance for curiosity.

My goal is to create a prototype, a symbiotic system between two opposite worlds, the one of the office worker and the artist. One that's grounded, in evidence of the current situation in Canary Wharf and the shift in its reason to be, and a transferrable model for future shared uses.

The STRATEGY

Reuse is the premise.

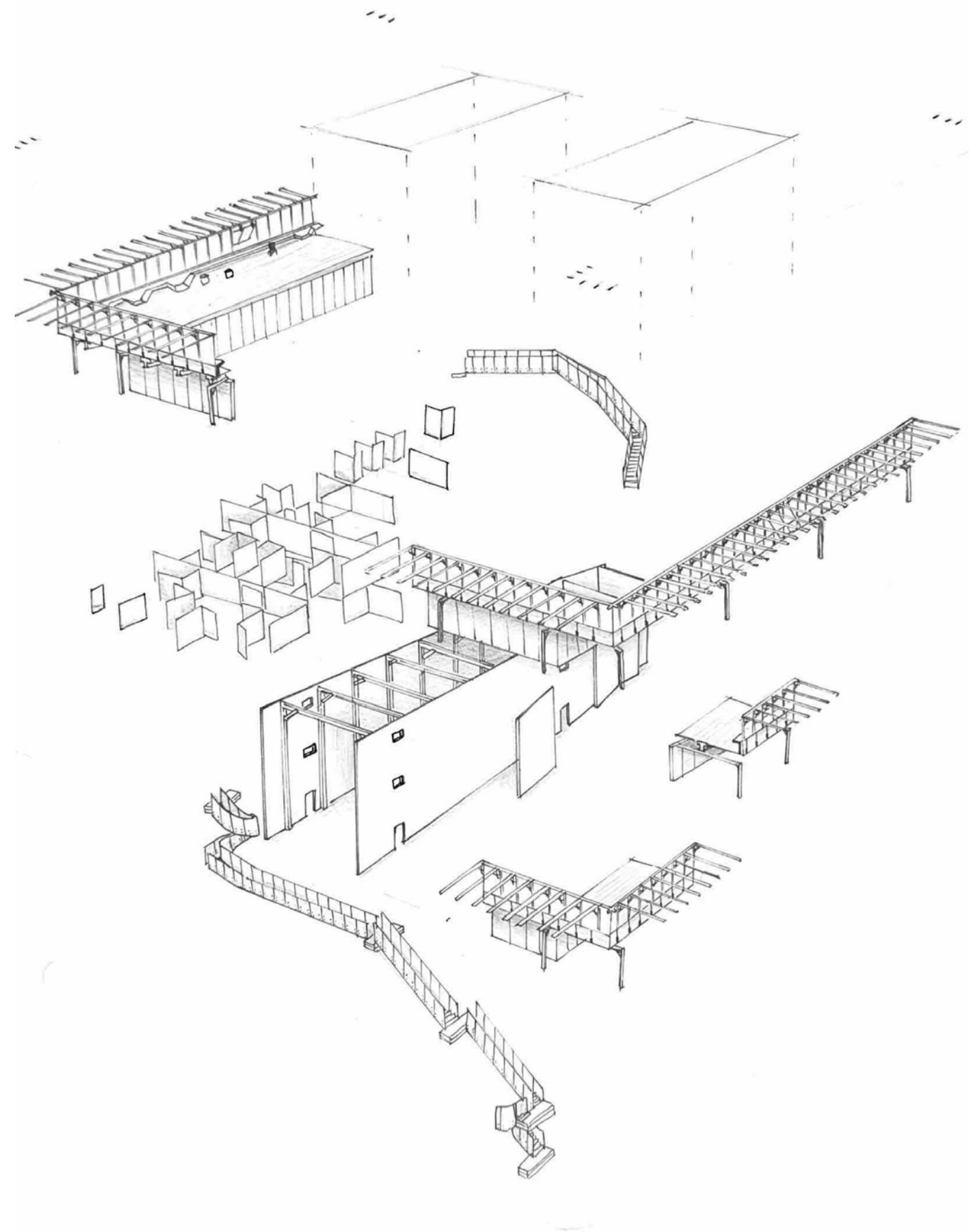
Carving is the method.

Programming (the unlikely tenant) is the primary idea.

The Unlikely Tenant is a site-specific proposal for 33 Canada Square, developed as a demonstrator of a transferable strategy: reusing redundant towers as civic infrastructure to bring opposite worlds together.

The building is the test case, and the method is deliverable and applicable.

A risk I face with this project is falling into a "decorative" act. Placing culture into a corporate tower can just add to the facelessness I'm trying to break. That is why I keep the programme about making rather than cosmetic: studios and workshops, not art curated to entertain a corporate tenant. The "spine" which is the new circulation is a public route in, so the cultural life the building hosts is open to the area instead of staying closed off, and strategically connects all my pockets of programme.



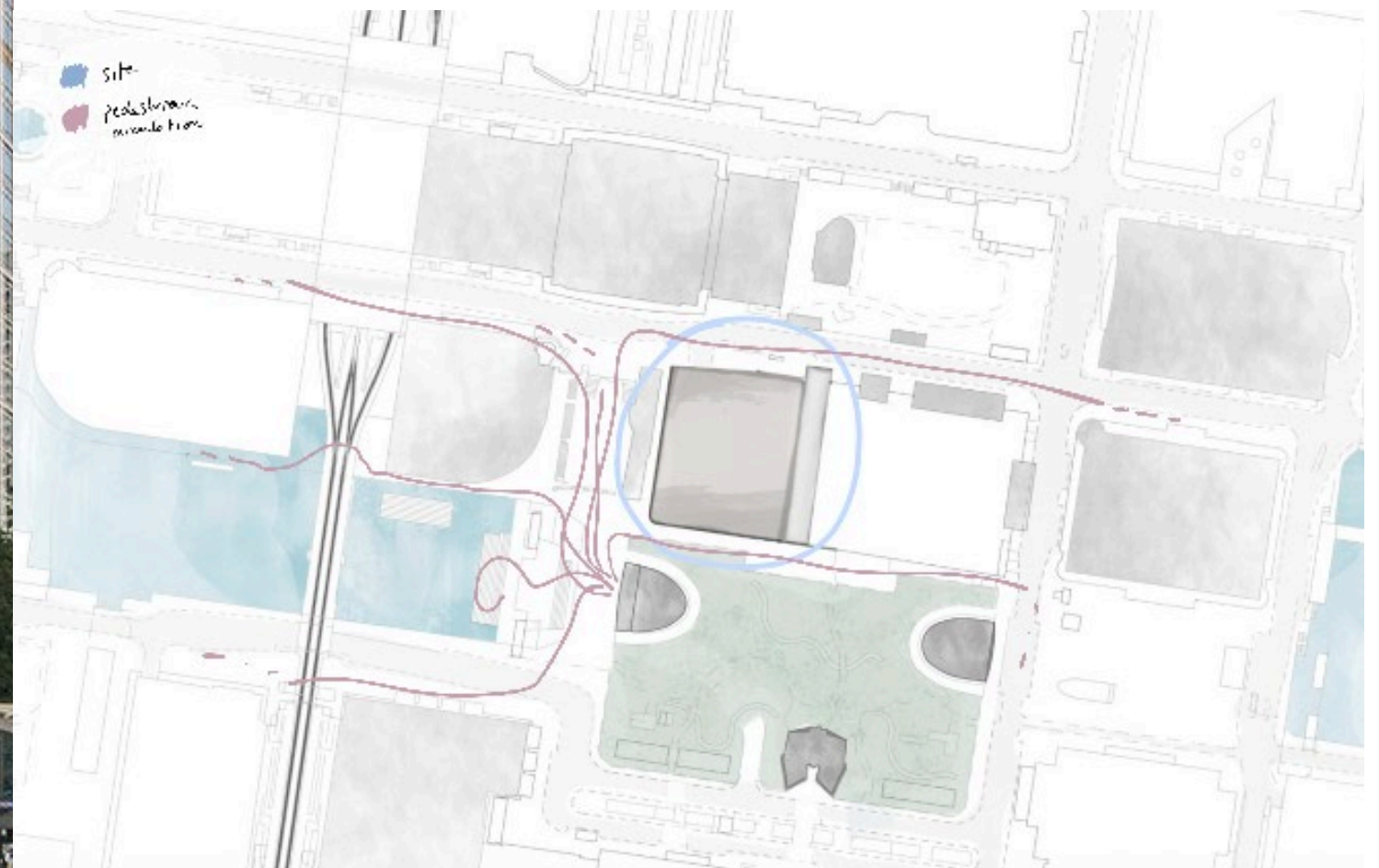
Hand drawing, pen on paper



The SITE

Due to the intentions for my project and programme, I chose 33 Canada Square as my site. It's an office building originally designed and built in 1999 by Fosters and Partners. It consists of 18 floors, 105 meters tall. Each floor plan has a measurement of 51 x 62m. The main design element in this building are two atriums that go through each floor to invite natural light.

I chose this building as it's located in the center of Canary Wharf and therefore is hard to miss. Every day there is a 100.000 footfall in front of it, both office workers and tourists. I wanted to do something bold and radical in the context of Canary Wharf, therefore this building would act as a beacon for the rest of the area.



1. Structural Reduction of Office Use

Canary Wharf office space is projected to **fall** from **83%** to **75%** by 2028, driven by hybrid work and **reduced demand** for large headquarters (Financial Times).

2. Rising Vacancy Rates

Office occupancy fell below 85% (2023), with **vacancy rising** to 15.87%, and reaching 19% by 2025, among the **highest in London** (Financial Times, Raconteur).



Solution: reuse existing fabric rather than build new.

3. Under-Utilised & Subleased Space

About **900,000 sq m** of office space is available for sublease --> built, leased, but **no longer needed** (Financial Times).

4. Corporate Downsizing & Consolidation

HSBC and others **reduced** their office **footprint** by around **40%** (The Guardian).

6. Growth of Flexible Workspaces

Around **400,000 sq m** in Canary Wharf is now occupied by **flexible workspace providers**.



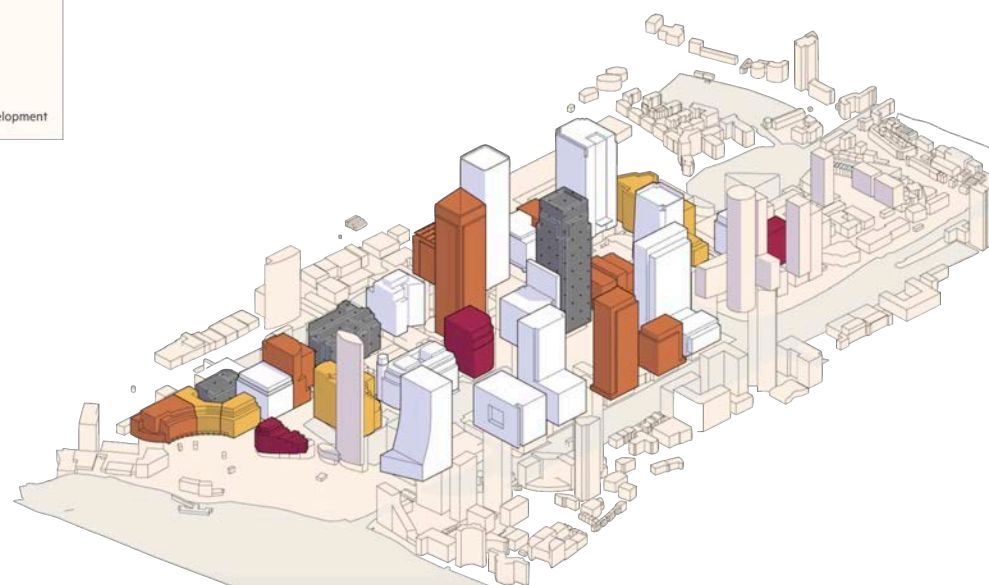
Opportunity: insert flexible making/working space where corporate space is emptying.

7. Changing Use & Public Presence

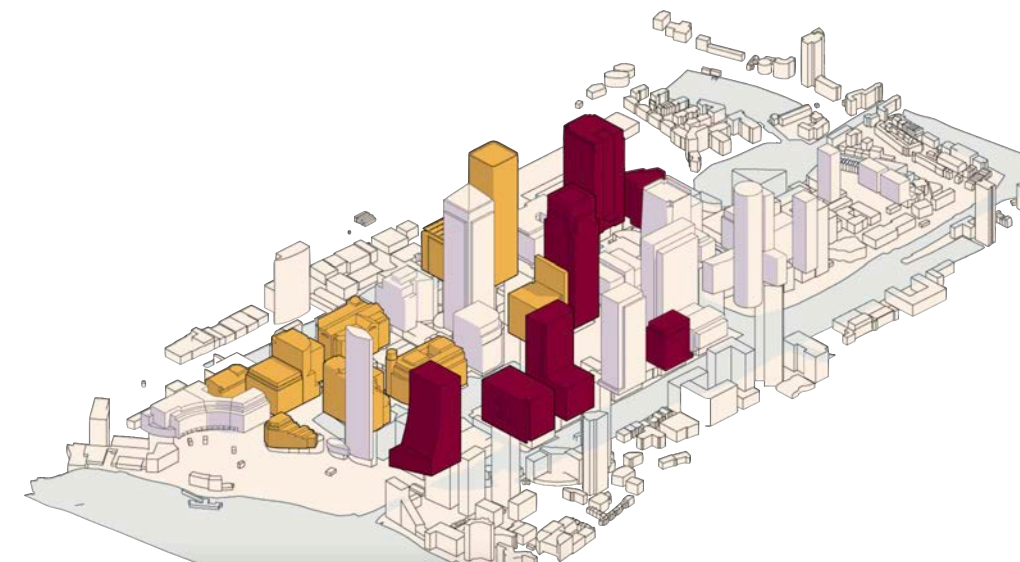
Canary Wharf recorded about **67 million visitors in 2024**, largely non-office users, showing a shift to an **all-round destination** (Canary Wharf Group).



Opportunity: programme is also public-facing (exhibition element, open ground floor).



Banks at one point occupied many of Canary Wharf's **office blocks**, but have committed to staying in just a few **flagship towers**



Research: OFFICE REDUNDANCY

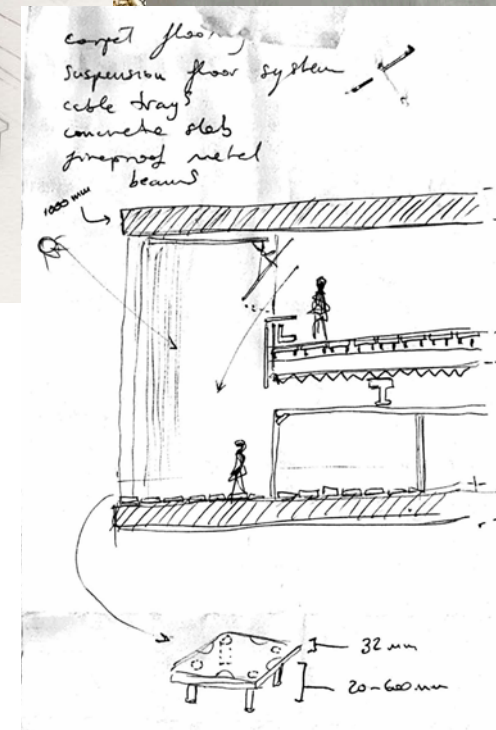
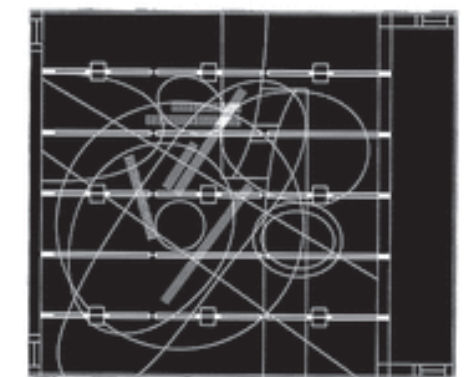
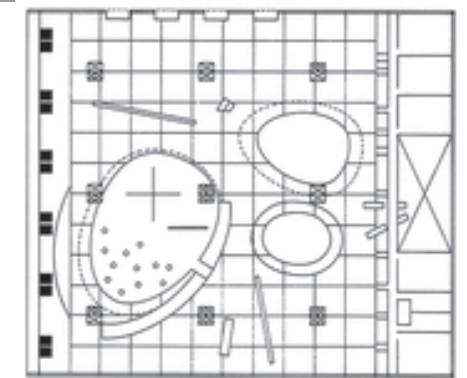
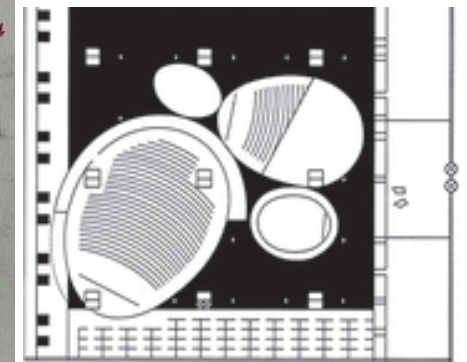
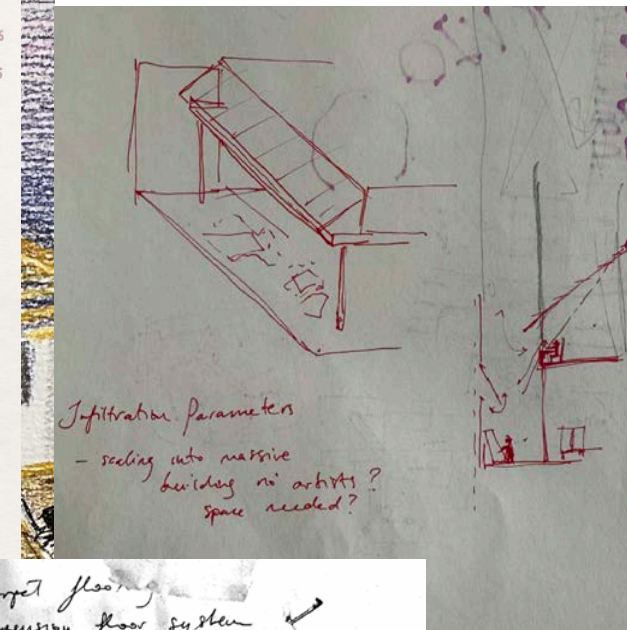
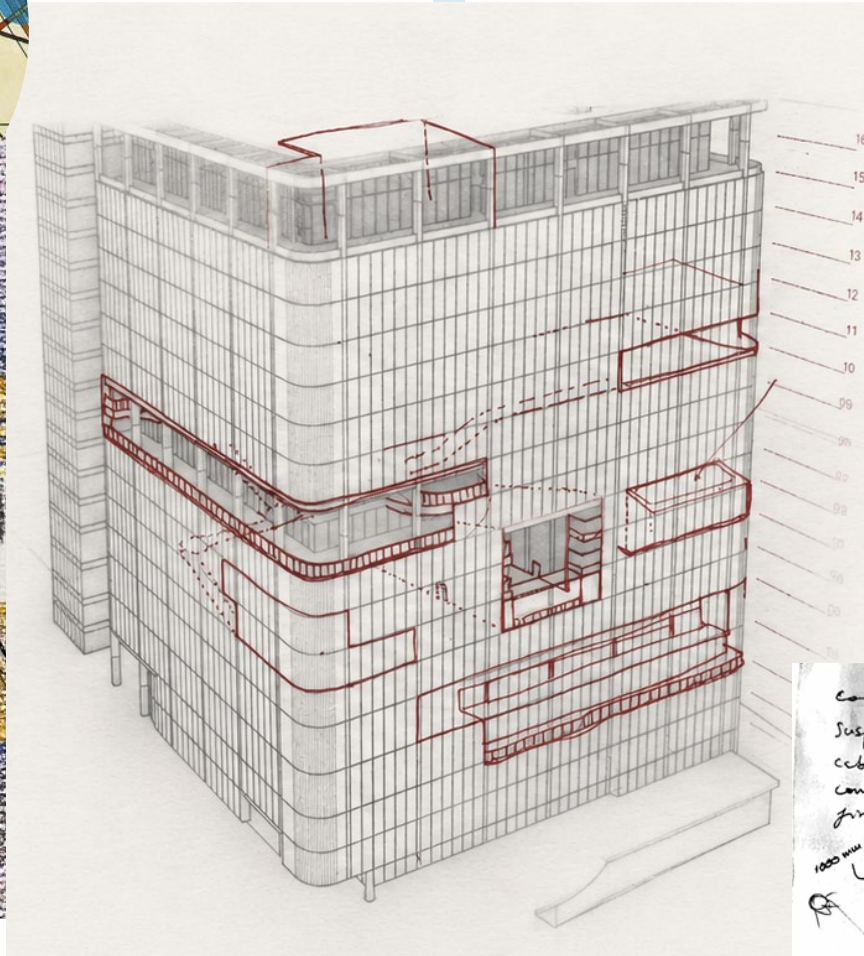
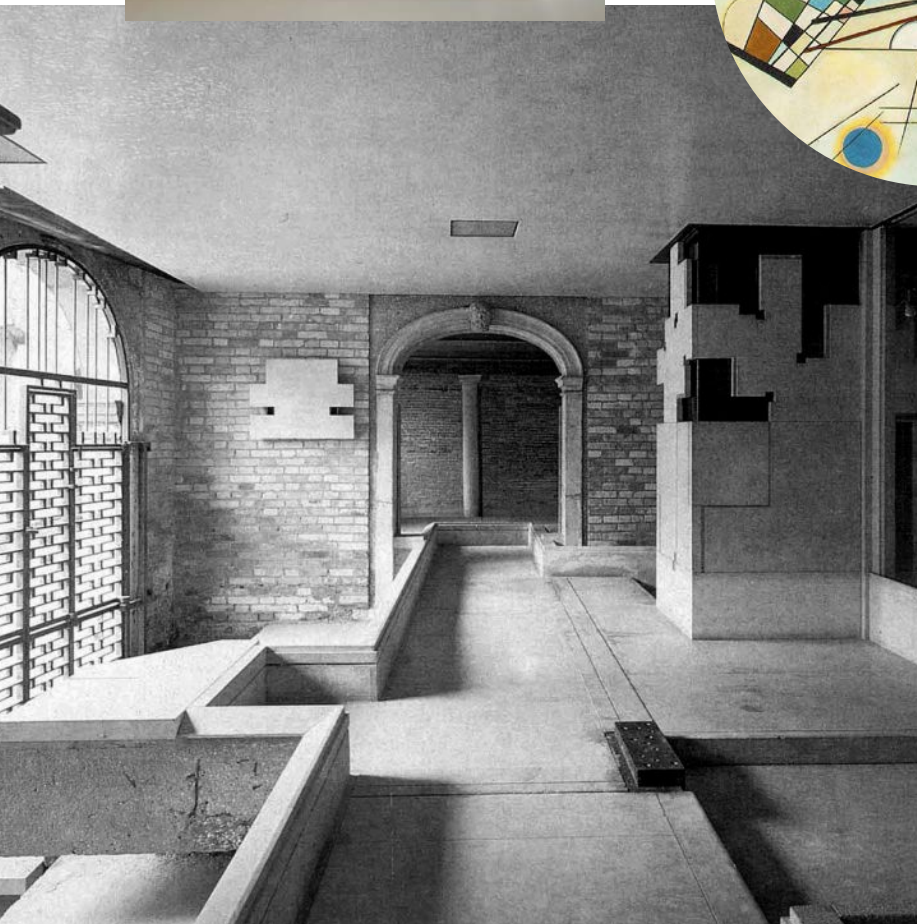


Kandinsky:
break the predictability of the
geometry and color palette of the
existing structure



the existing fabric of the building. It was at this point that I also started to latch more onto my Compression Artefact and everything that it symbolizes.

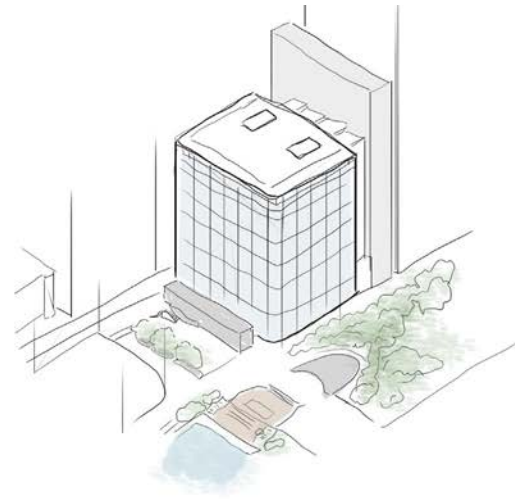
All sketches produced by hand,
pen on paper/tracing paper



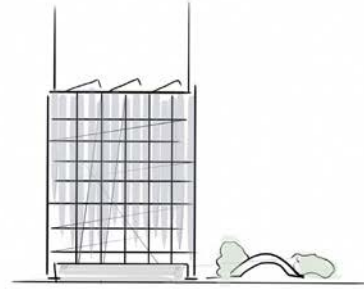
OMA, Theory of Void:
carve programmatic voids into the
repetitive

Concept DEVELOPMENT, Case STUDIES

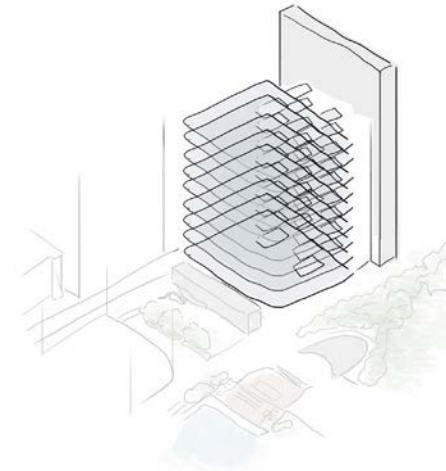
After my research, spanning detail inspiration (Casa Ma-setti, Carlo Scarpa, Kandinsky, Bauhaus) to case studies such as the Theory of Void by OMA, I started refining the structure of my program and produced a variety of drawings and diagrams to start playing with the idea of inserting these pockets, views of my programme into



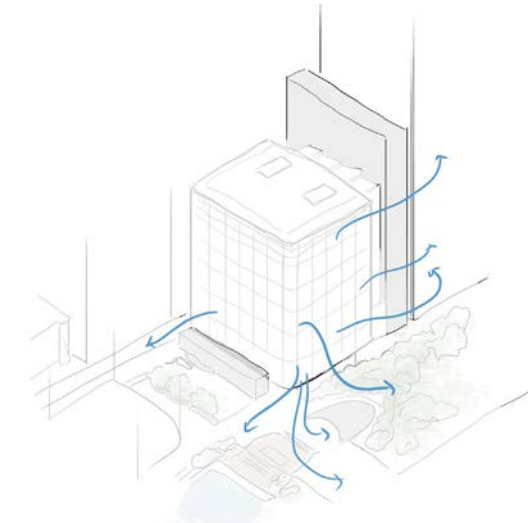
EXISTING



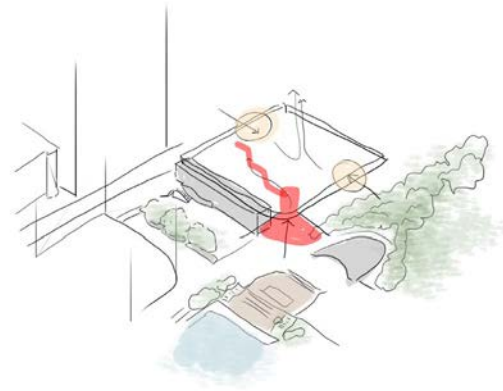
FACELESS



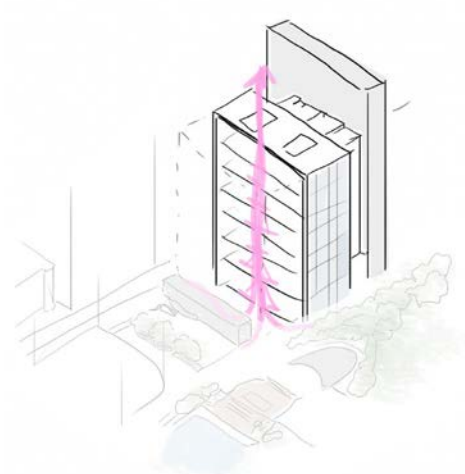
REPETITIVE
PLANS & GRID



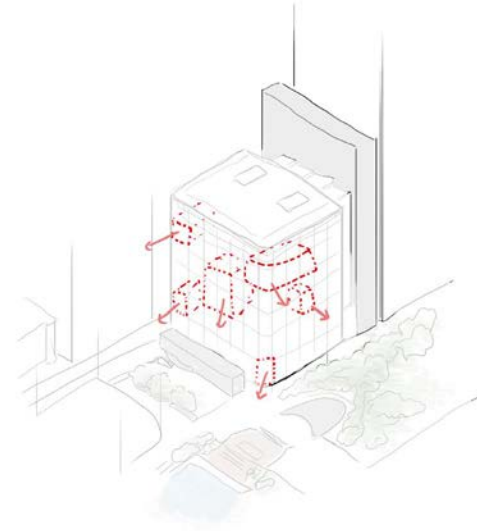
OFFICE
REDUNDANCY



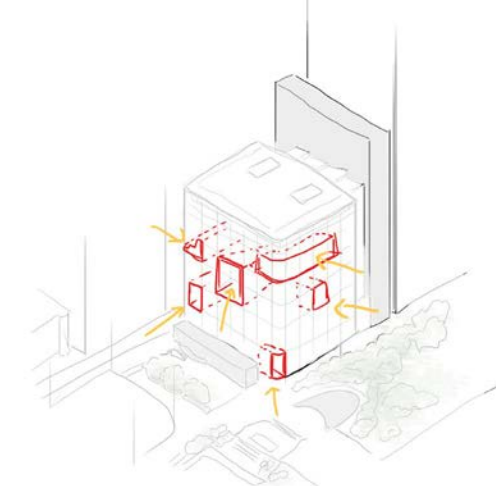
OPEN GROUND
FLOOR



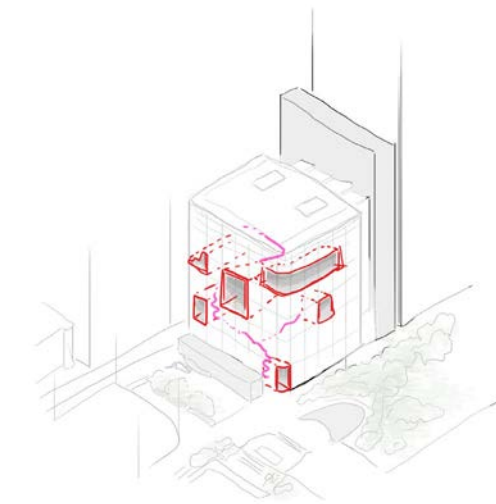
ACTIVATE, ADD
'SPINE'



CARVE OUT
'VIEWS'



INSERT NEW
POCKETS OF
PROGRAMME



CONNECT

Parti DIAGRAM

Programme ELEMENTS

The project inserts and infiltrates itself into the existing structure, revealing processes of care and work. A series of pockets of interventions act as a spine for the building. These spaces consist of independent and group artist studios, joinery workshops, exhibition space and informal areas for independent working, allowing making and working to exist side by side. The intention is to soften the rigid, transactional atmosphere of Canary Wharf and shift it towards something more civic in nature.

Four constraints shaped the design:

- the structural grid and 51x62m floorplans (where the programme can be carved in)
- daylight (studios face NE for uniform light)
- servicing/noise (joinery at floor 01 with a heavy-duty lift, away from the upper studios).
- the existing inner walls

Timber and oak offcuts for new cladding for art spaces

New heavy duty lift for joinery machinery and painting transport vertically

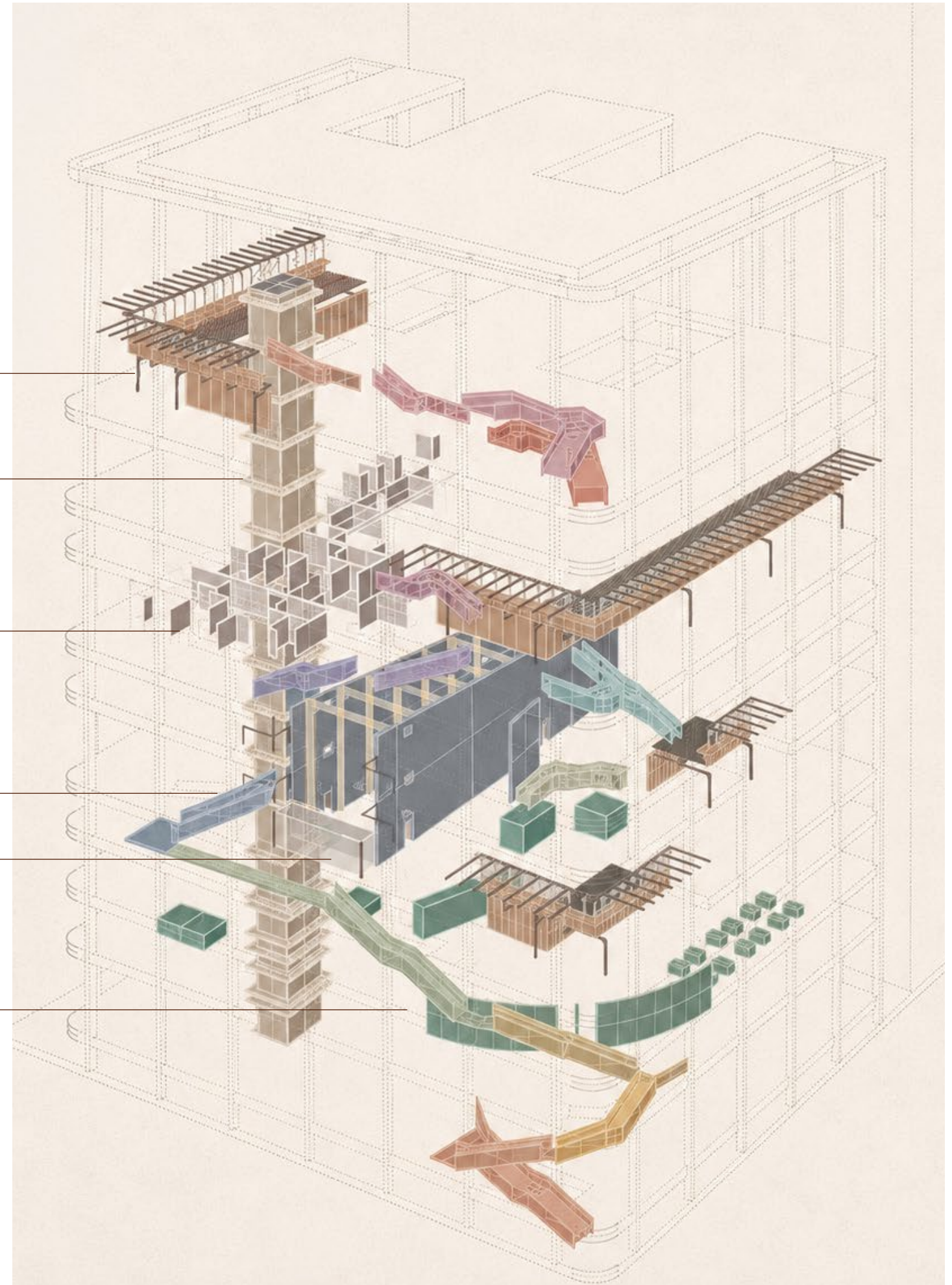
Independent artist studios facing NE for more uniform light to work with

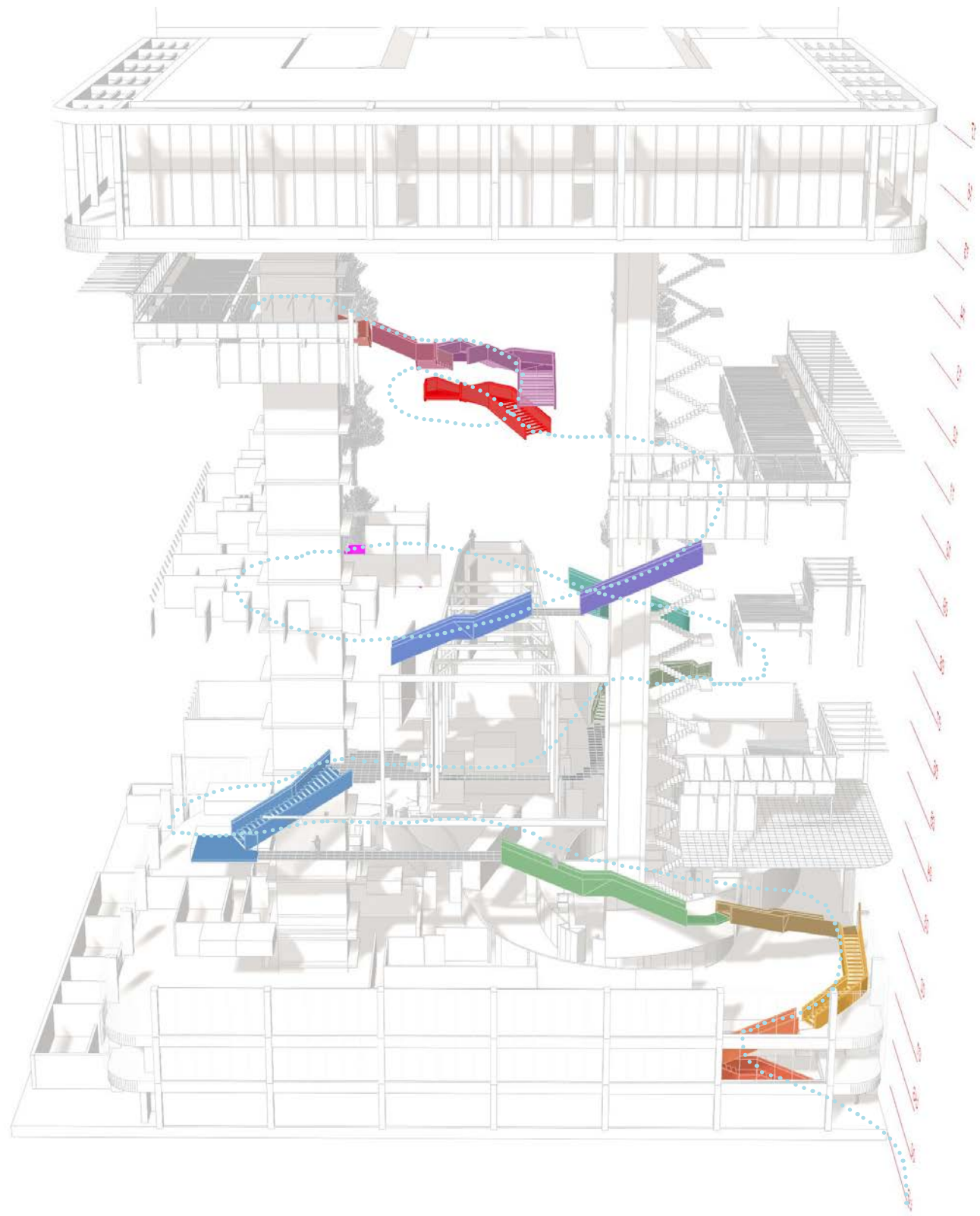
New circulation route exposing the anatomy of building as visual guide

The 'heart' of the programme: the exhibition gallery bringing together all people

Joinery floor at 01 for less noise pollution for upper floors

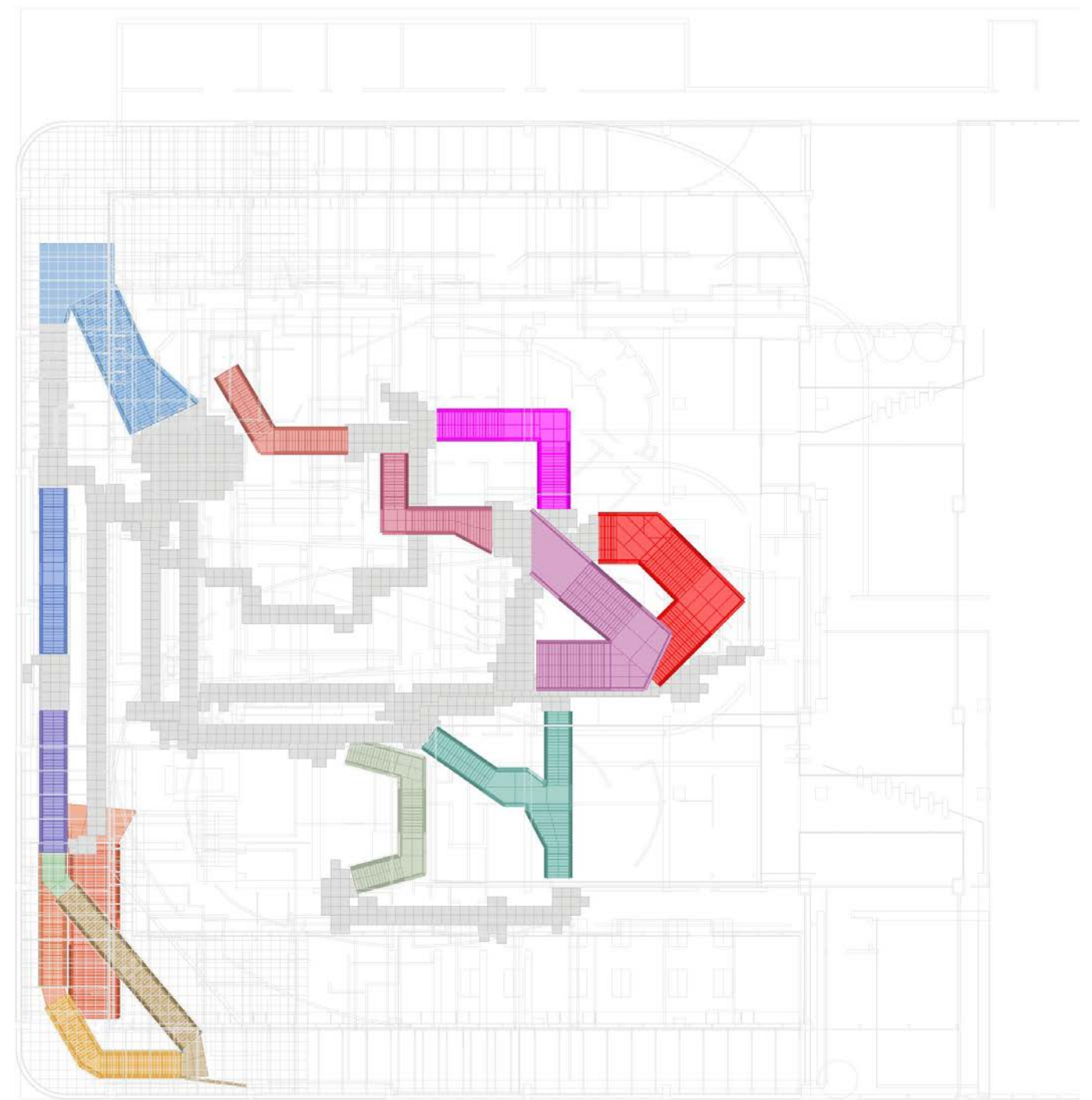
Rhino - Make 2D, then Photoshop editing with Wacom tablet





New CIRCULATION

Everything is stitched together by a dedicated new circulation route characterized by a colorful staircase to contrast the color palette of the structure. The dotted line on the left hand



side diagram follows the path throughout the new building's circulation.

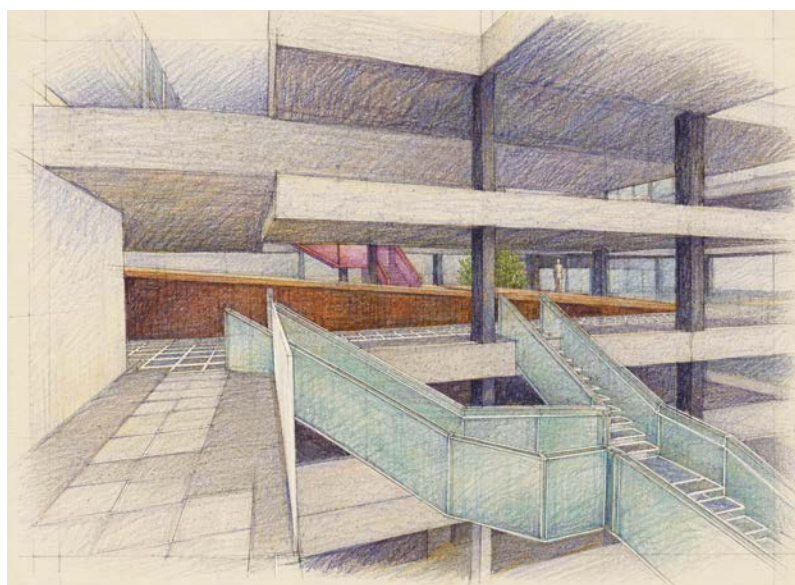
Rhino - Make 2D, then in-software hatching

Front SECTION



Side SECTION





Sketches

Rhino model +
Google maps overlay +
Photoshop





MODELS

Lateral models produced by hand
with recycled materials
Central model produced with
46 acrylic laser cut sheets

YUMTEA

Asian Bakery and Coffee Shop in High Holborn, London

Commercial Interior Fit-Out

Completed: March 2025

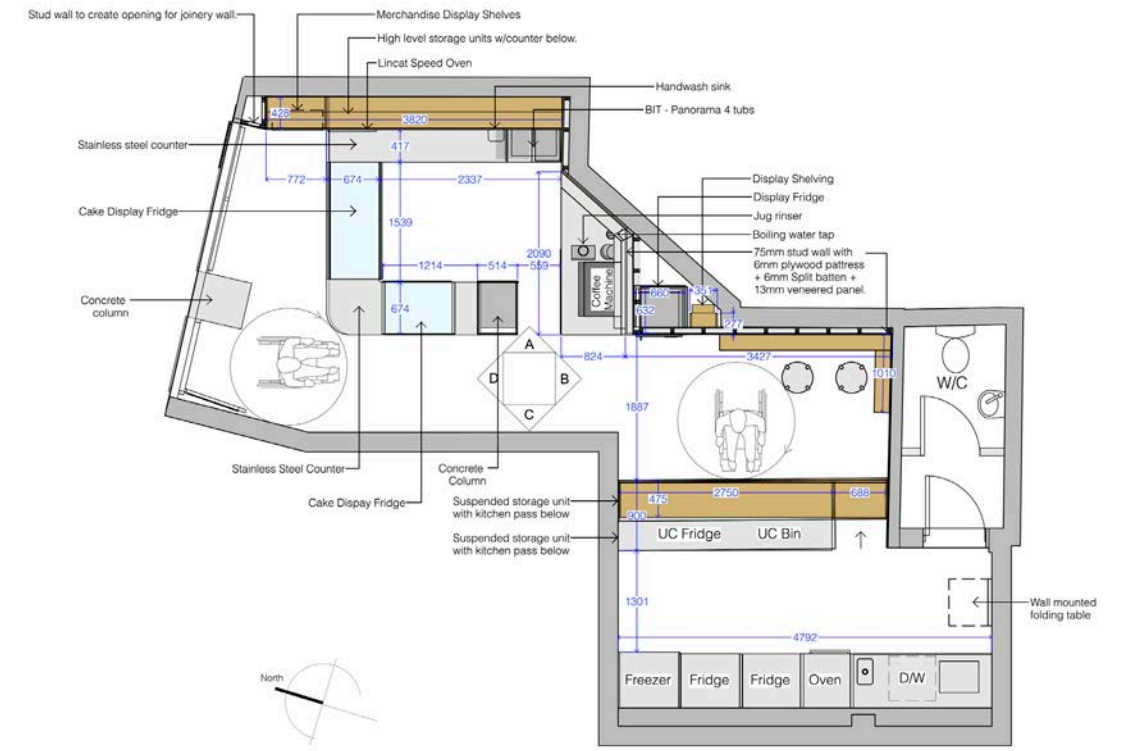
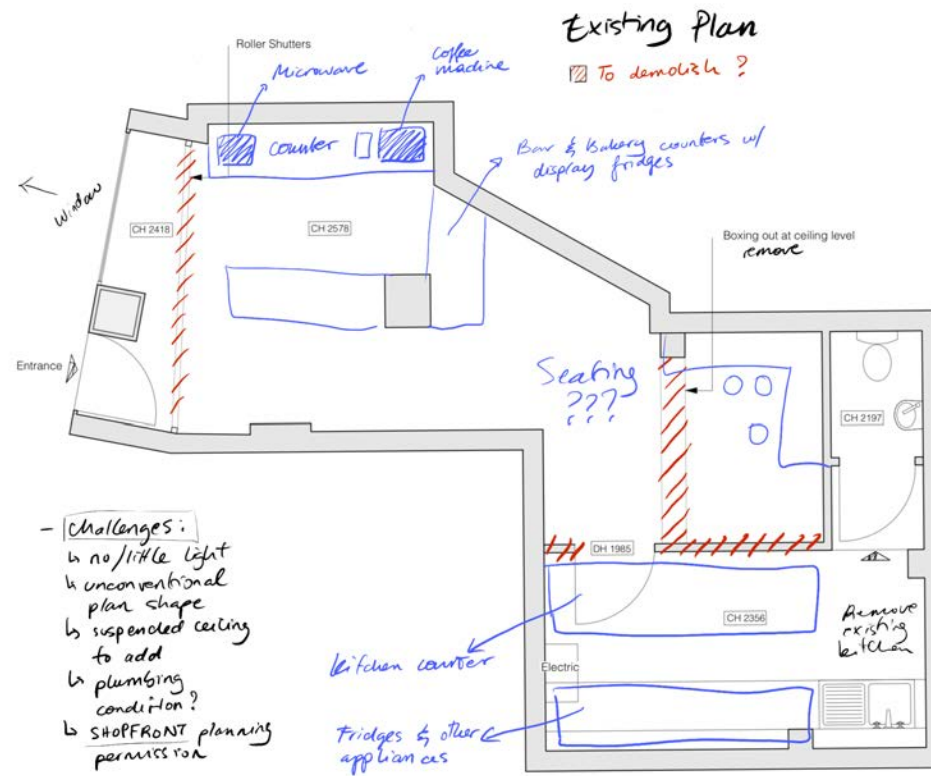
Role: Design Assistant at EASTJR

YUMTEA is a contemporary Asian bakery and tea shop located in High Holborn, where I was involved from the initial concept through to completion. The project aimed to deliver a refined and compact retail and café experience, combining warm materiality with a renovated playful branding.

My Role

- Client liaison, site visits & surveys
- 2D technical drawing production
- Interior layout & material coordination
- Shopfront vinyl & branding graphics
- Presentation decks & sample curation
- On-site and post-installation support

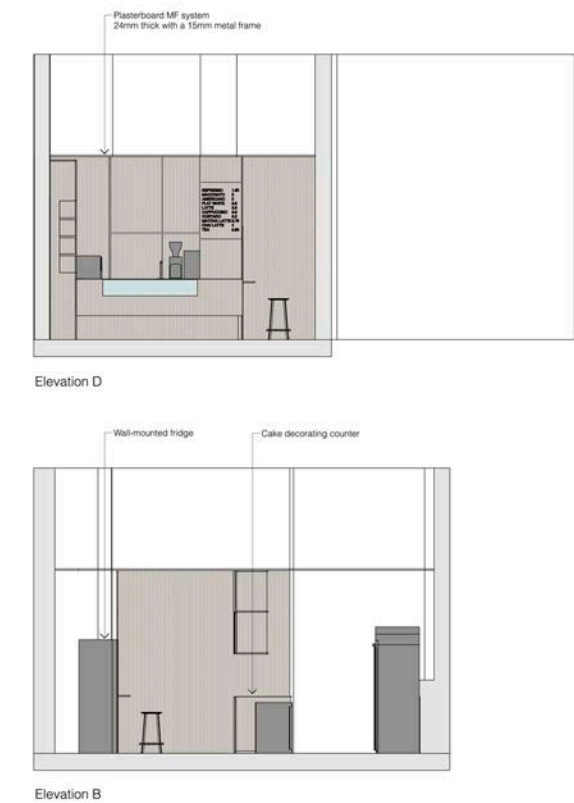
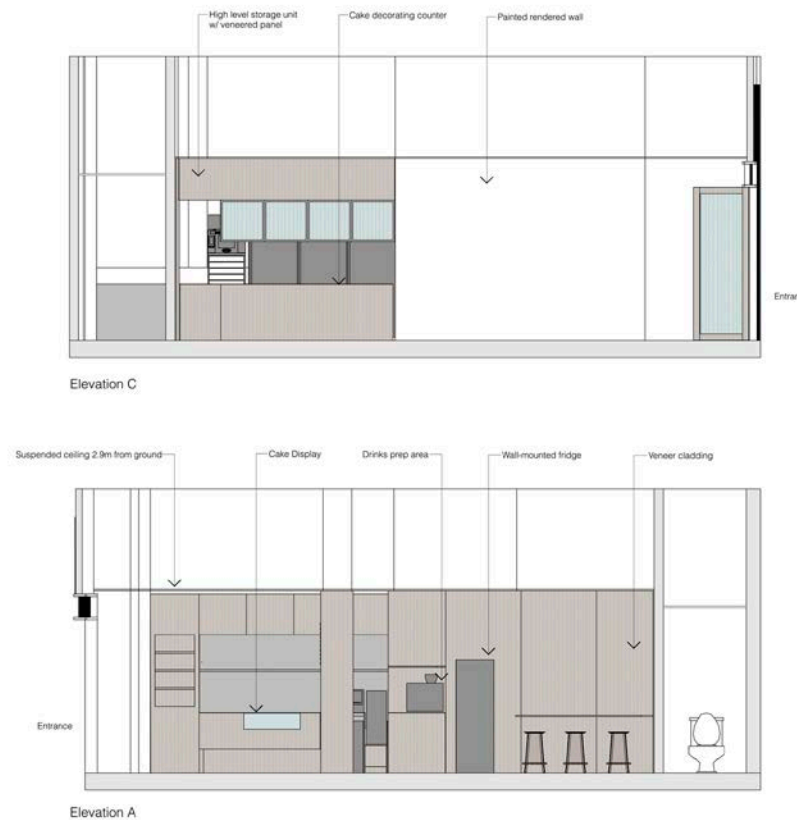




Plans & ELEVATIONS

The challenge was to come up with a design that was more pertaining to the client's vision and to stem away from their existing first shop design in Canary Wharf.

The unconventional floorplan and overall geometries of the shop meant we had to work around its limitations when it came to the positioning of each element to ensure enough space for staff and for client circulation.

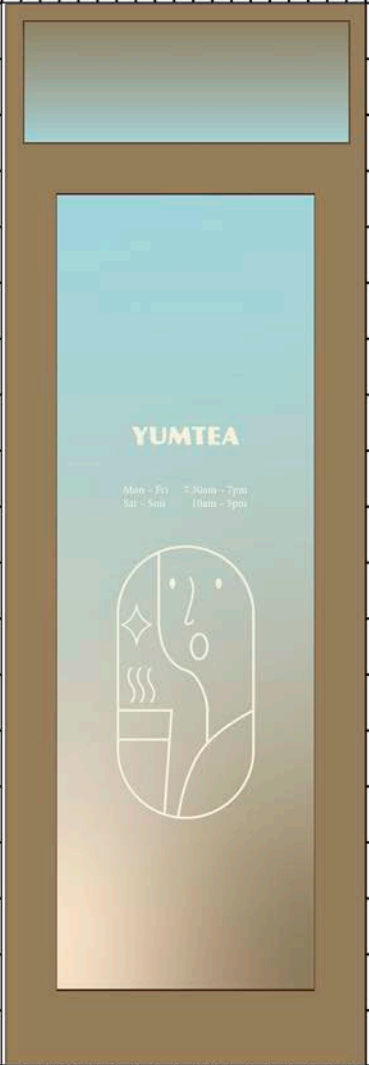
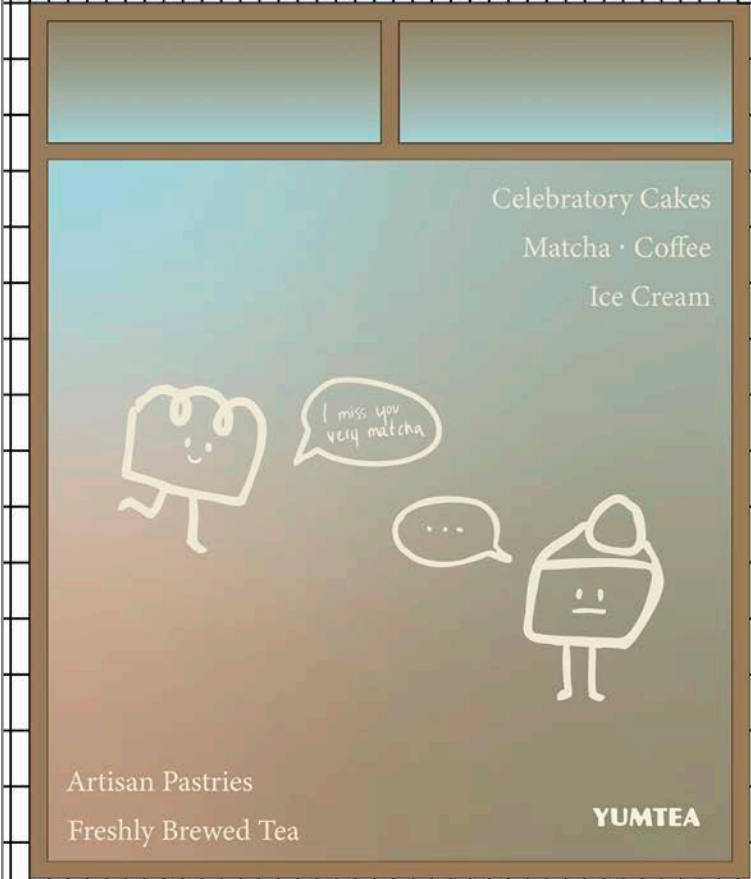


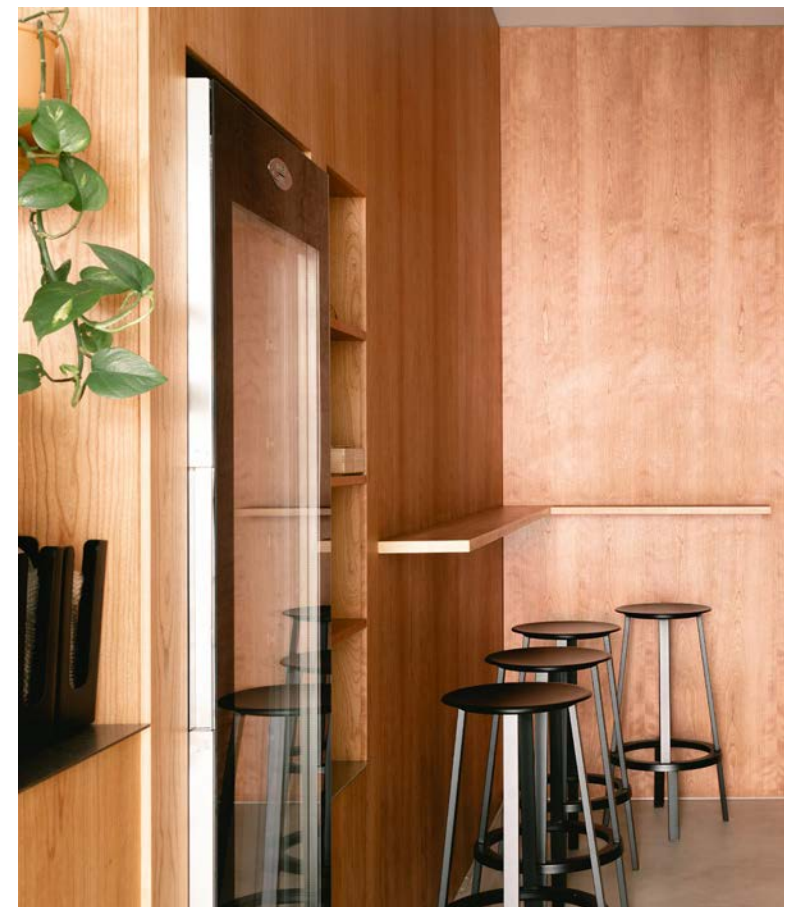
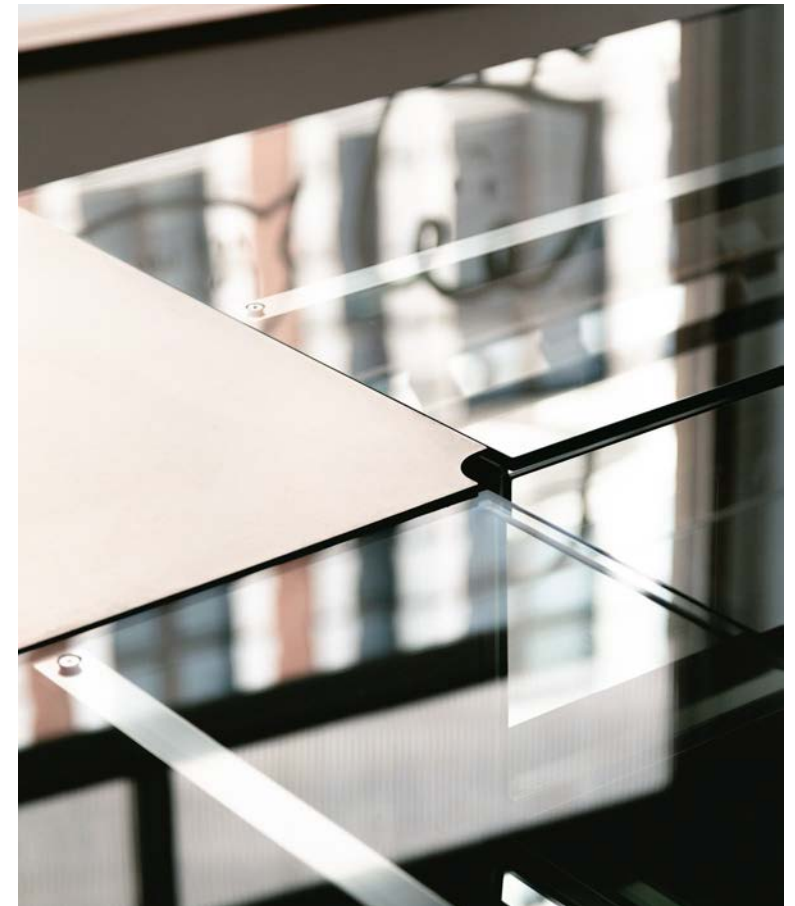
Shopfront VINYLs

Among the other aspects of design to which I contributed, I offered to come up with a new design for the Yumtea shopfront design. I stayed true to the client's desires and came up with a hand drawn, graphically appealing and fun vinyl that best represents the business and their strongest selling points.



YUMTEA





East JR. Coordinated by Viola Pica. Photography by Lewis Gregory

Nagare BANKSIDE

Coffee Shop for Nagare Coffee in London Bridge

Commercial Interior Fit-Out

Completed: March 2025

Role: Design Assistant at EASTJR

A full interior design and technical delivery for Nagare's newest flagship café, inspired by Japanese minimalism and slow-living culture. The space of 162 m2 merges bakery operations, high-spec coffee equipment, and bespoke joinery solutions for both workflow and guest experience.

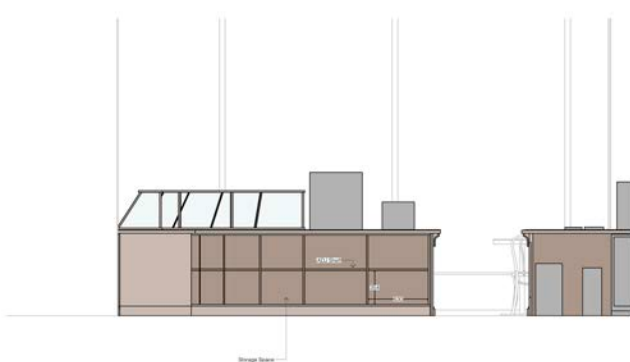
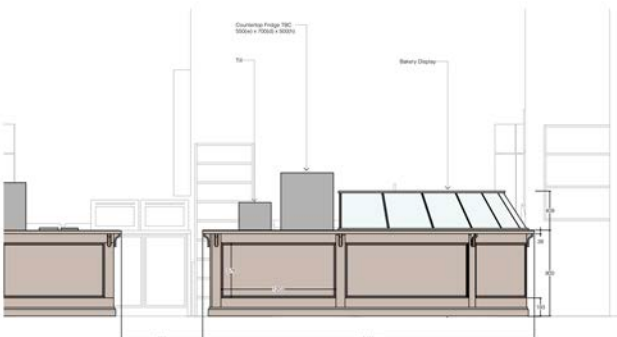
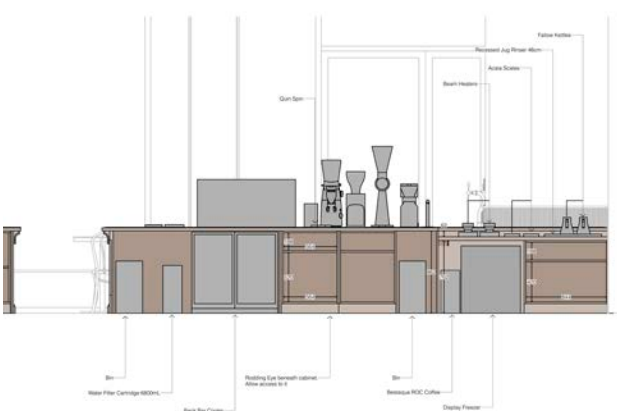
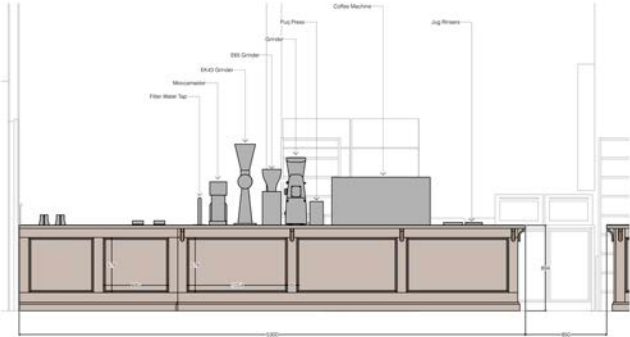
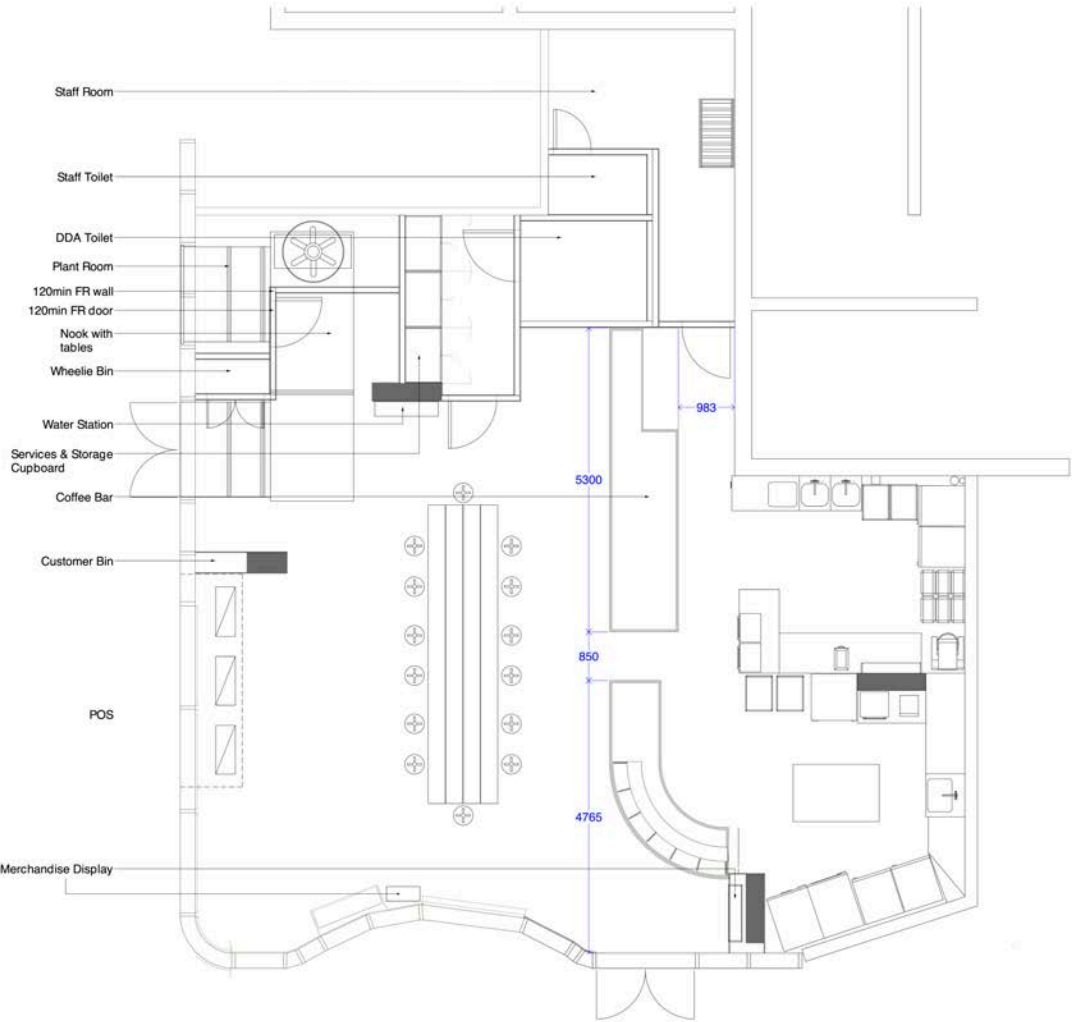
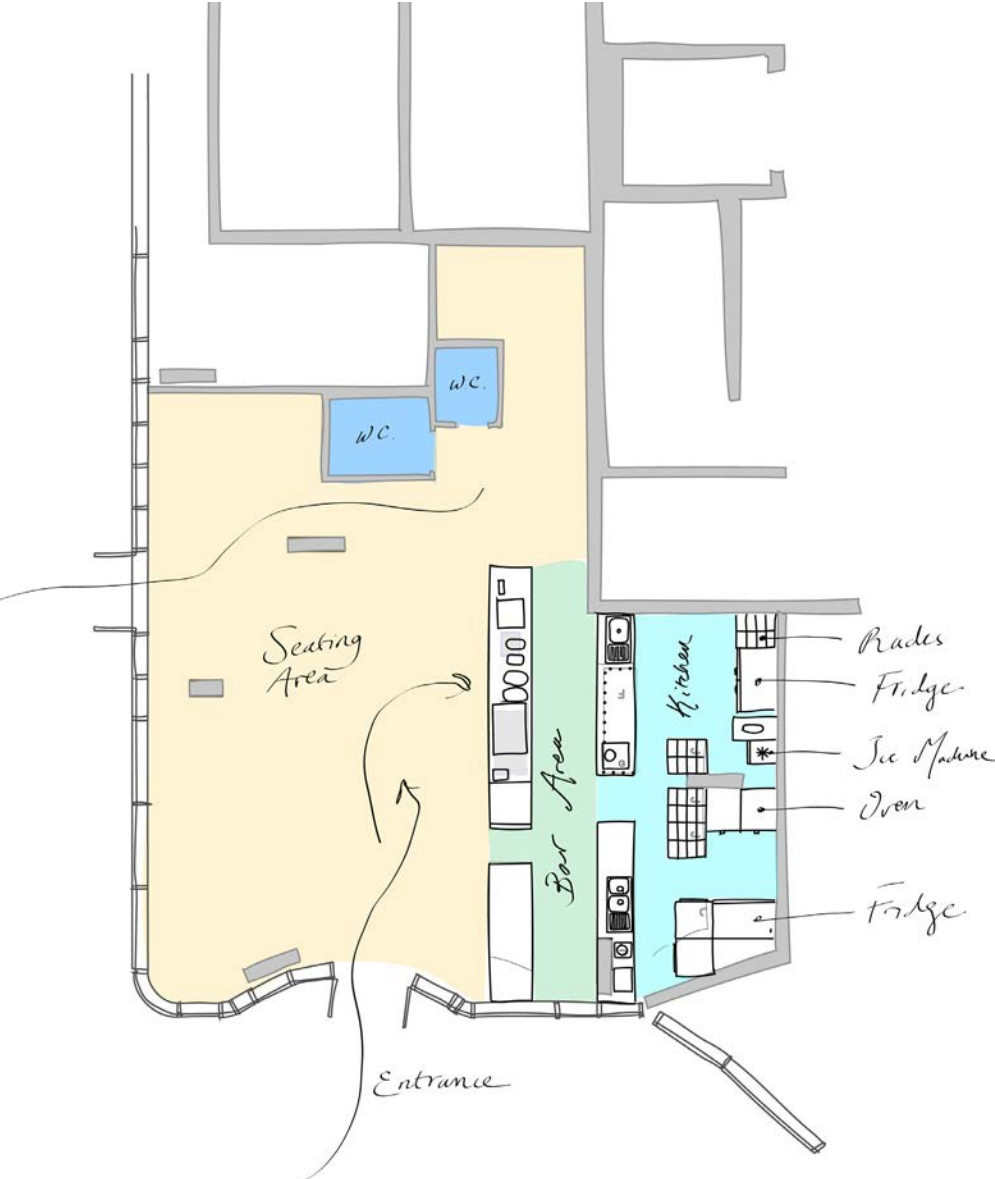
My Role

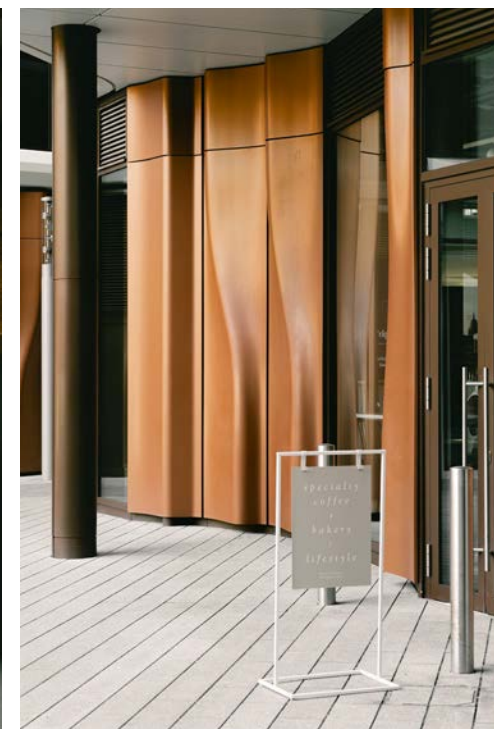
- Client meetings, site visits & surveys
- Involvement in RIBA stages 0–4
- 2D technical drawing production
- Interior layout & material coordination
- Presentation design packages
- Construction photography



Plans & ELEVATIONS

The challenge for this project was to be able to convey the same atmosphere as in Nagare's original coffee shop (images above) in the recently opened Triptych Bankside modern housing development, which has a contrasting tone.





East JR. Coordinated by Viola Pica. Photography by Lewis Gregory

In Progress PHOTOGRAPHY

Towards the end of construction I went on site to take some professional pictures of the team working on the joinery pieces to showcase the various elements of talent. I shot and edited this selection of images.



Story of STOREYS

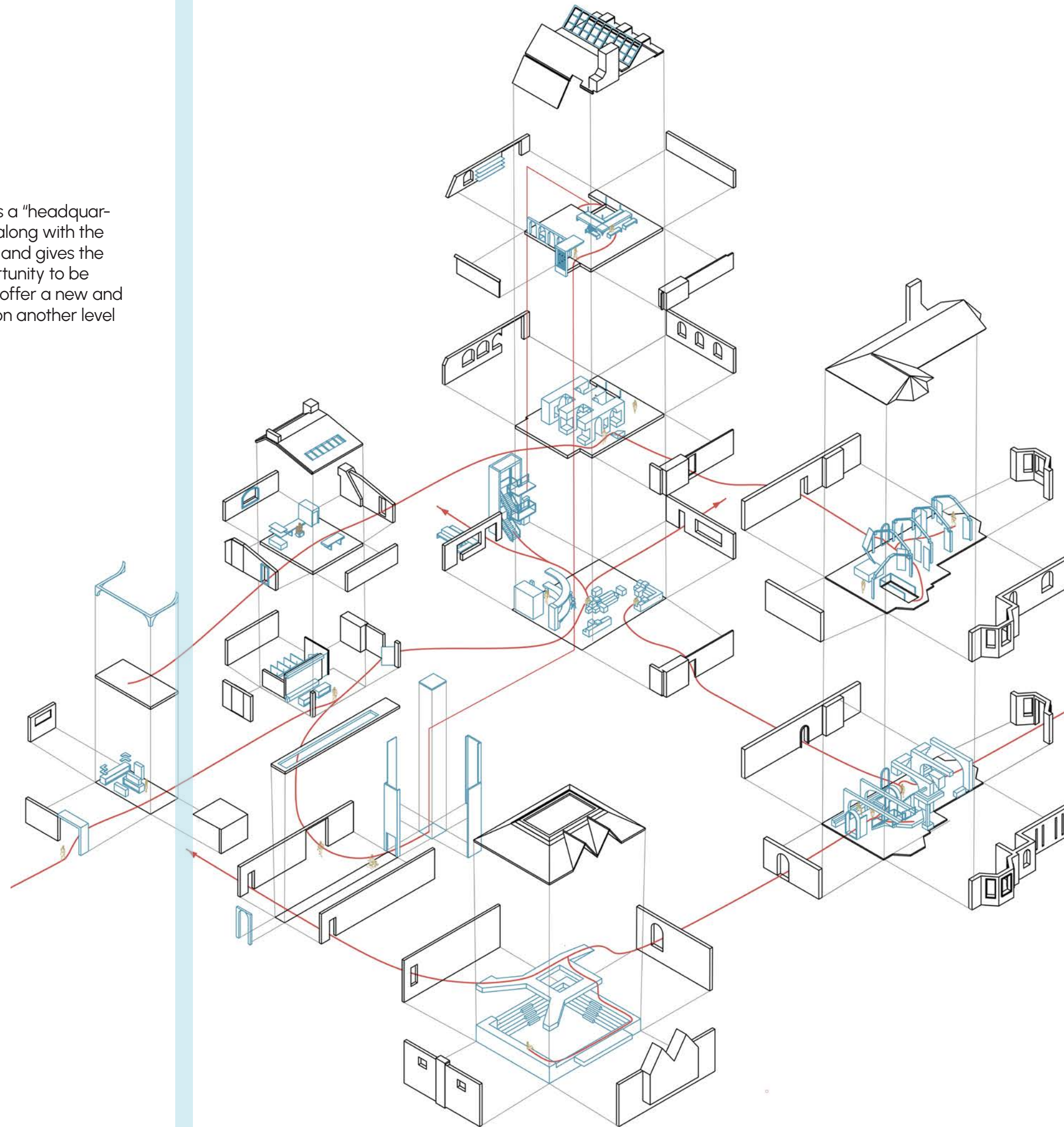
Final Major Project | Catford Constitutional Club Repurposing

The task of this project was to redefine the role of the museum, and what its meaning might entail in the future. The program gives a new purpose to the Catford Constitutional Club, dating as back as the 1700s.

The locally listed structure is now open to the public in the form of an Art Centre consisting of a café, an art shop, artist studio spaces, a seminar room, and mainly exhibition spaces.

The focus on community uses and social value creates a new definition of public house that accommodates artworks in a way that makes

it accessible for all. This provides a "headquarters", gives voice to local artists along with the contribution of non-local artists, and gives the community of Catford an opportunity to be exposed to artistic themes that offer a new and yet down-to-earth experience on another level of emotional sensitivity.



The SITE



Hand drawing w/
watercolors



Falling Girl

A life that is consumed in pursuit of the big occasion

Superfluous Invitations

conjuring up pieces of one's romantic past.

The Colombe

the fear of facing one's limits and the attraction to the unknown

7 Floors

Ineluctability of destiny

The 7 Messengers

Metaphor of the man who separates himself from his origins to go in search of himself.

The Two Drivers

When by now discouragement seems to take over, hope still peeps out, a small hole opened by some 'intermittence of the heart'.

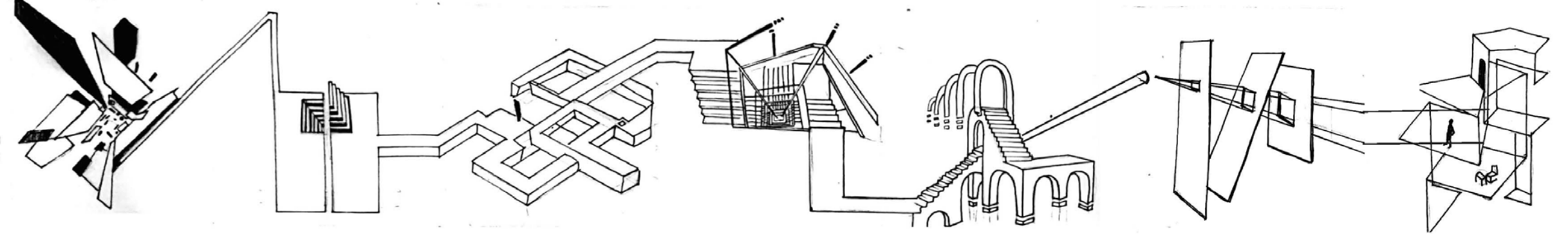
Memory of a Poet

the importance of remaining authentic to ourselves, refusing to settle in societal standards

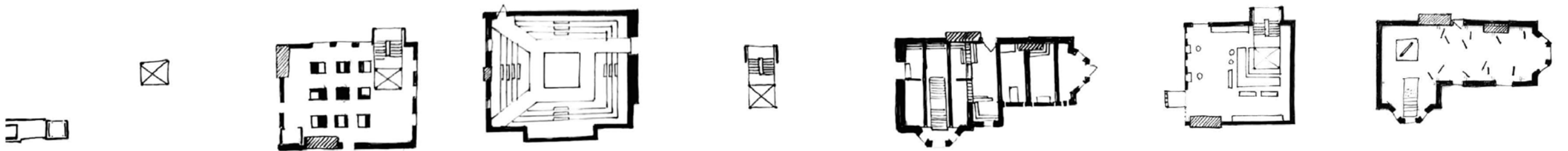
Personal literal representation of the story



Direct translation into architectural expression



Architectural expression represented in plan



Hand drawing, pen on paper

The "Architecturalization" of Stories. An analytical hand drawn diagram that shows the process of metamorphosis of the main brief stories chosen from the book "The Mystery Boutique" into architectural spaces.

The overall building acts as a storytelling device by channeling the themes in the curator's chosen book as inspiration for the architectural expressions and installations.

The Catford Constitutional Club is now revitalized and its historical significance elevated in the form of a place where visitors can find comfort in recognizing themselves and their experiences in the artworks and architectural expressions of the exhibitions.

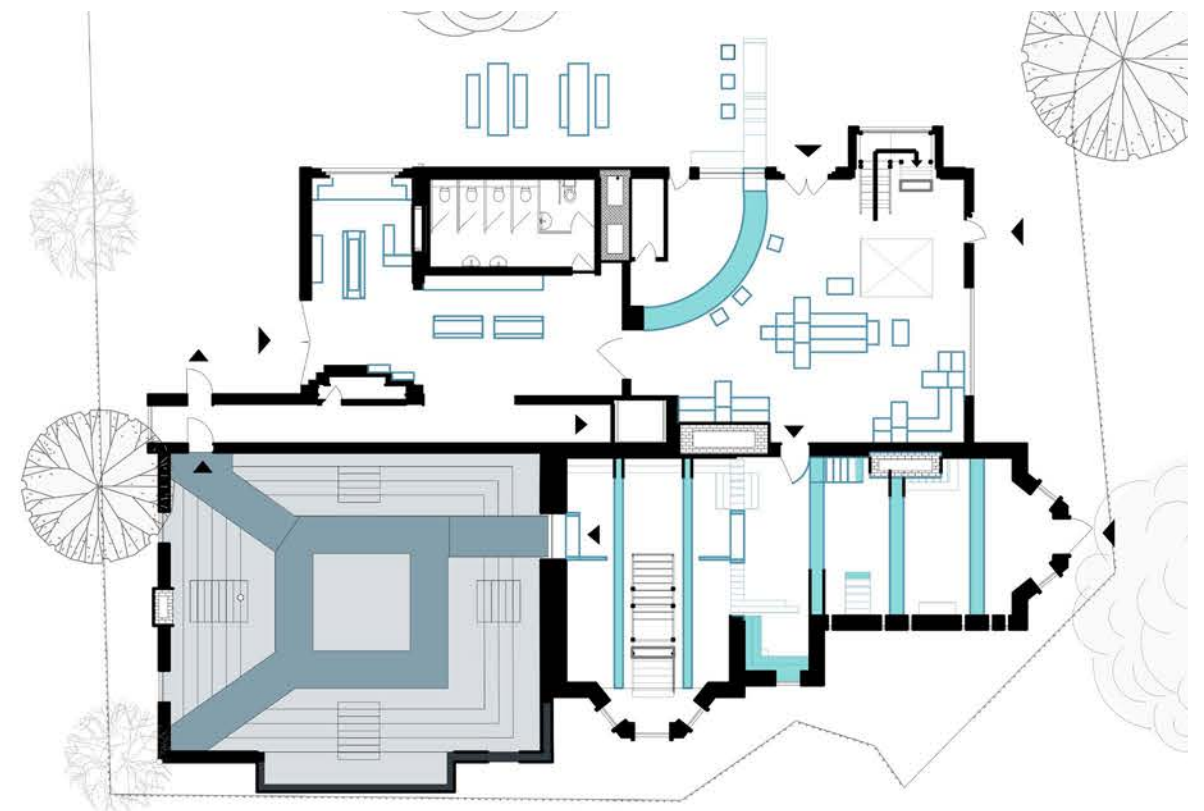
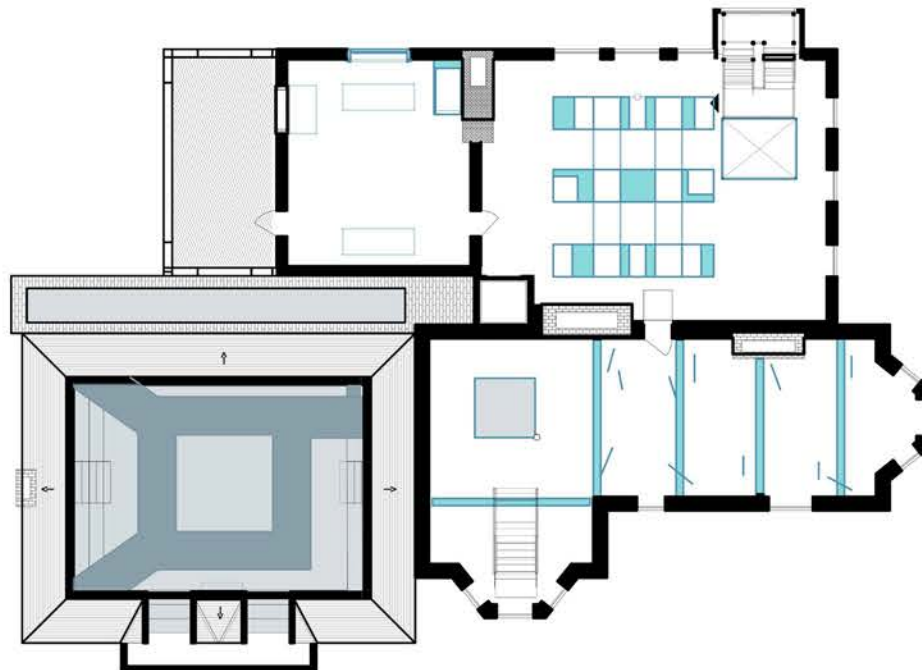
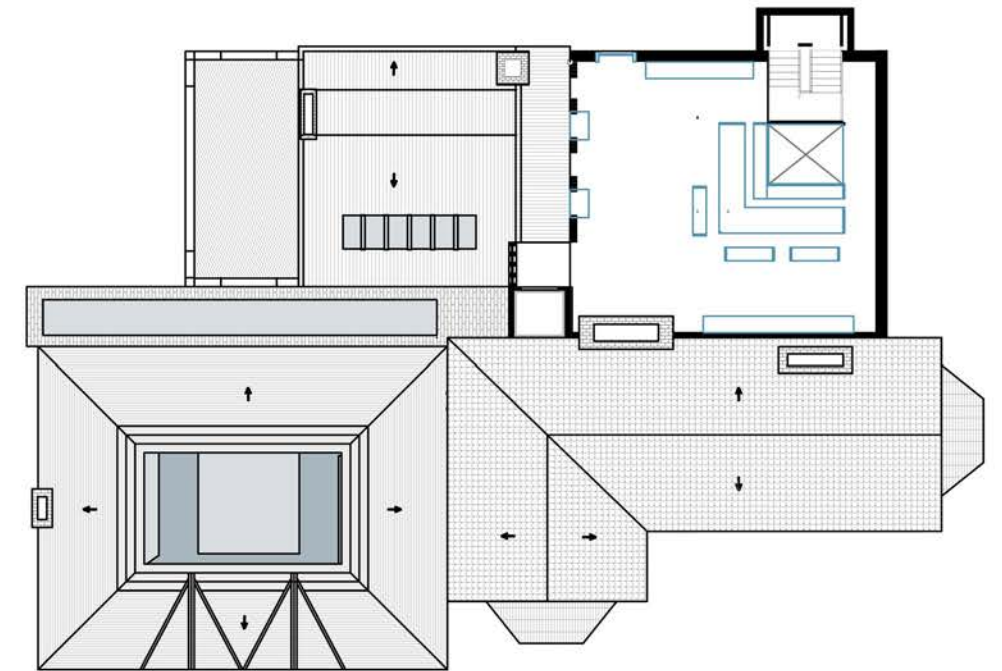
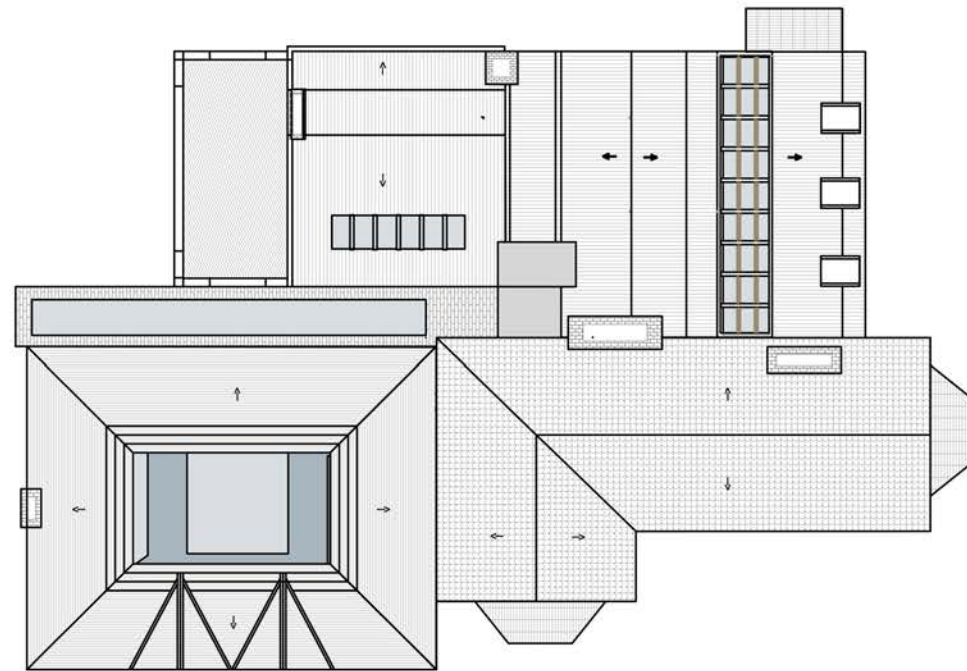
The PLANS

1:20 on A1

The program is comprised of the following spaces:

Entry/Art Shop
Bathrooms
Main Hallway to Platform Lift
Cafe Kitchen
Cafe
3 main exhibition rooms
Live exhibition room with stage
Library/Seminar Room
Artists Studio

The spaces are organized so that they revolve around the accessible platform lift that goes all the way to the third floor. The exhibition spaces are free flowing and people can circulate through them from any point in the building. The cafe at the ground floor provides direct access to the courtyard which holds more seat and leisure space.

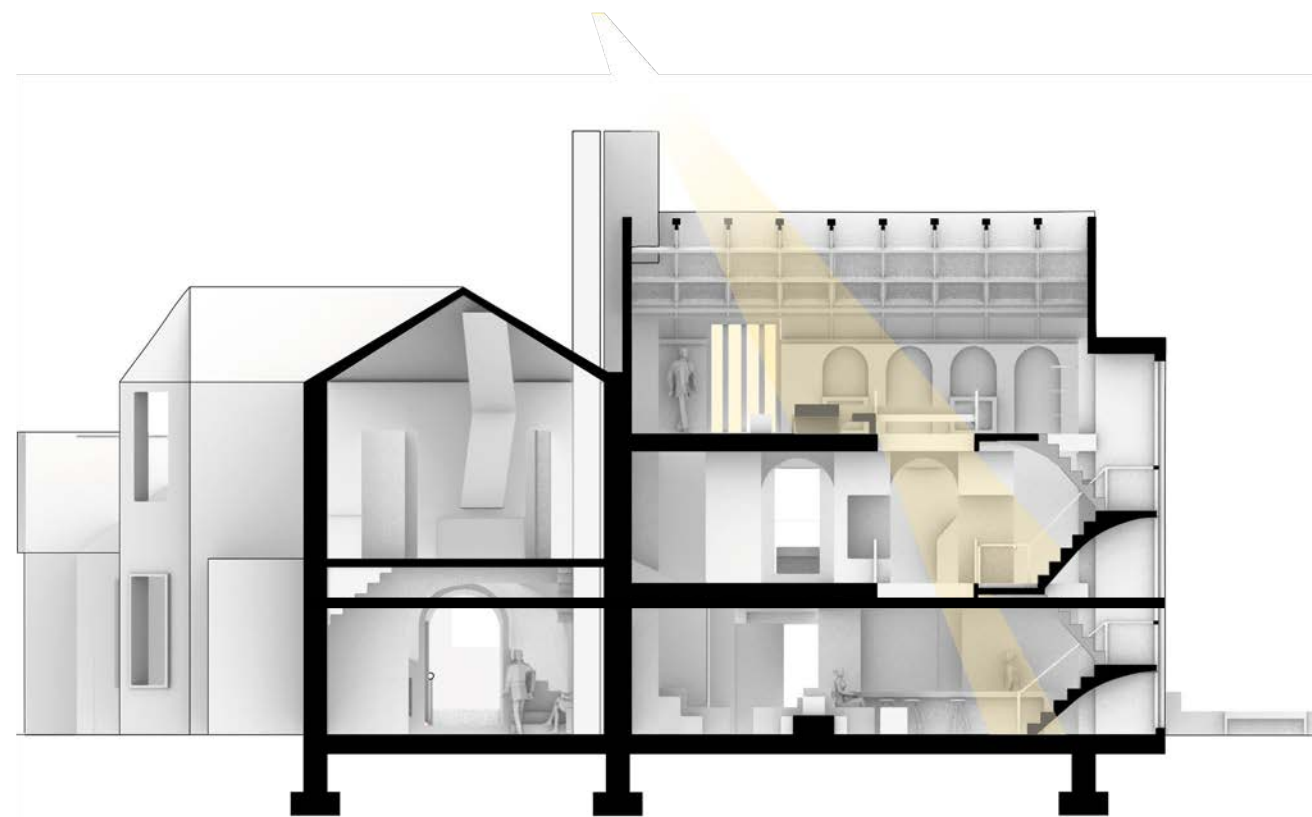
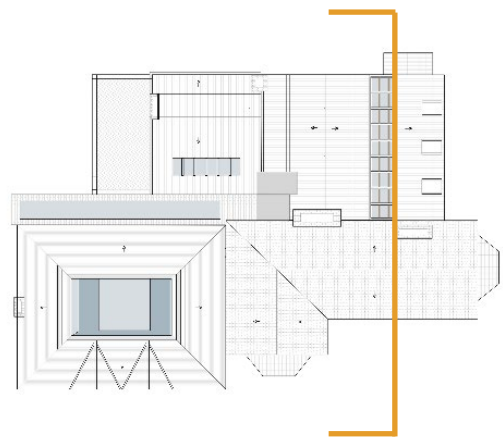


1 2 3 4 5 10

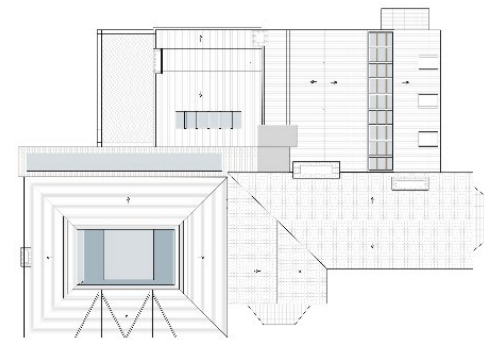


The SECTIONS

West Section
1:20 on A1



West Section
1:20 on A1



Materiality & Construction STRATEGY

Renovating an Existing Building

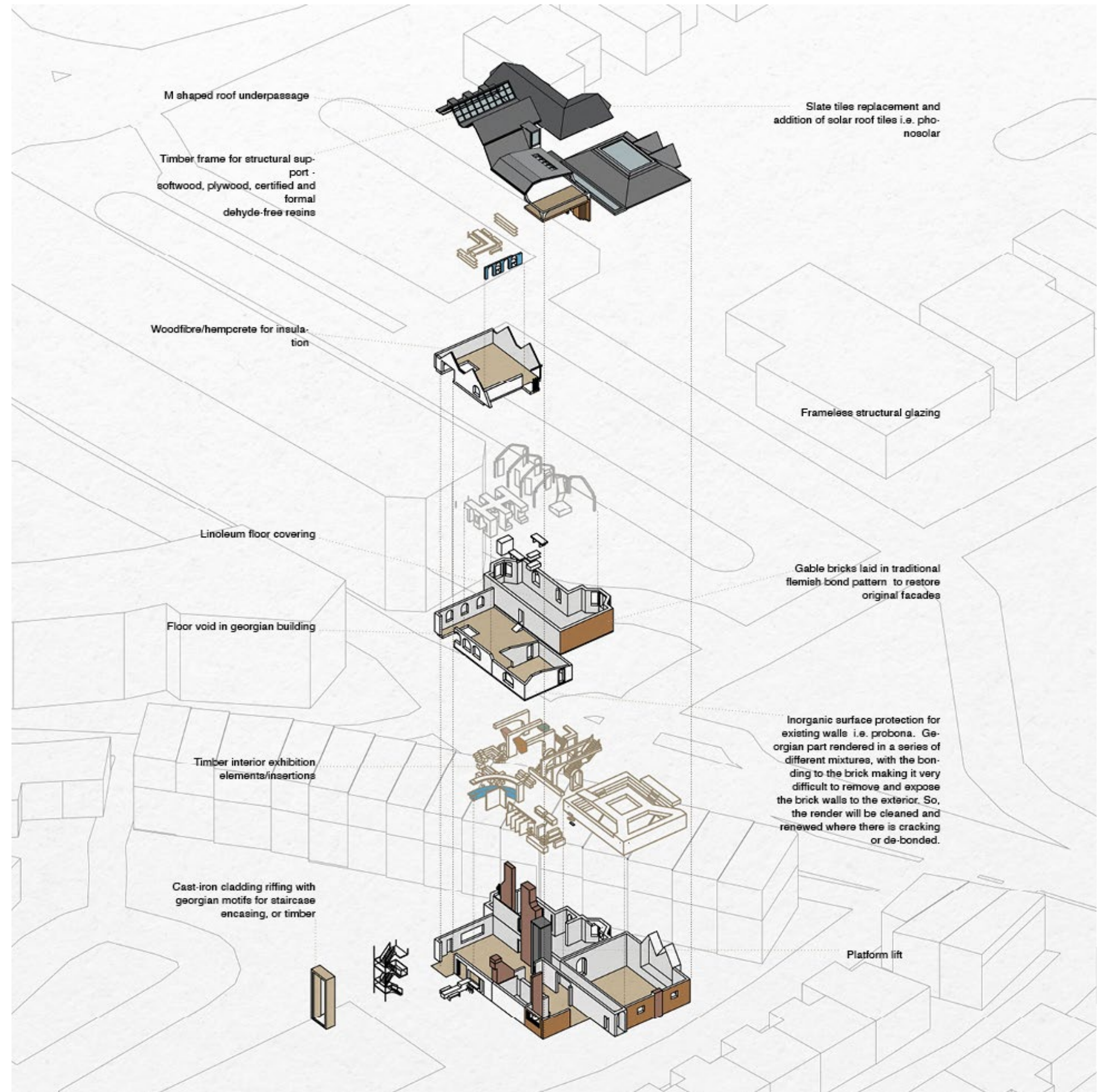
Working with an existing building usually means that the carbon emissions during construction decrease and the quantity of materials used isn't as much.

There is already a pretty significant amount of embodied carbon in the existing structure due to it being of Georgian and Victorian eras, therefore built mainly in brick. As a result, retaining the existing walls and simply renovating the appearance of certain parts will minimize additional carbon emissions.

Approaching the project with sustainability in mind implicates also the use of sustainable materials that contribute to the circular economy.



Rhino - Make 2D, then
Photoshop editing with
Wacom tablet



Construction Section DETAIL

Hand drawn, showing one of the main structural interventions (bench footing) to mold the space based on the program's needs

ROOF TILES FIXED TO BATTENS ON COUNTER BATTENS
BREATHABLE MEMBRANE
RAFTER FILLED WITH INSULATION (150MM)

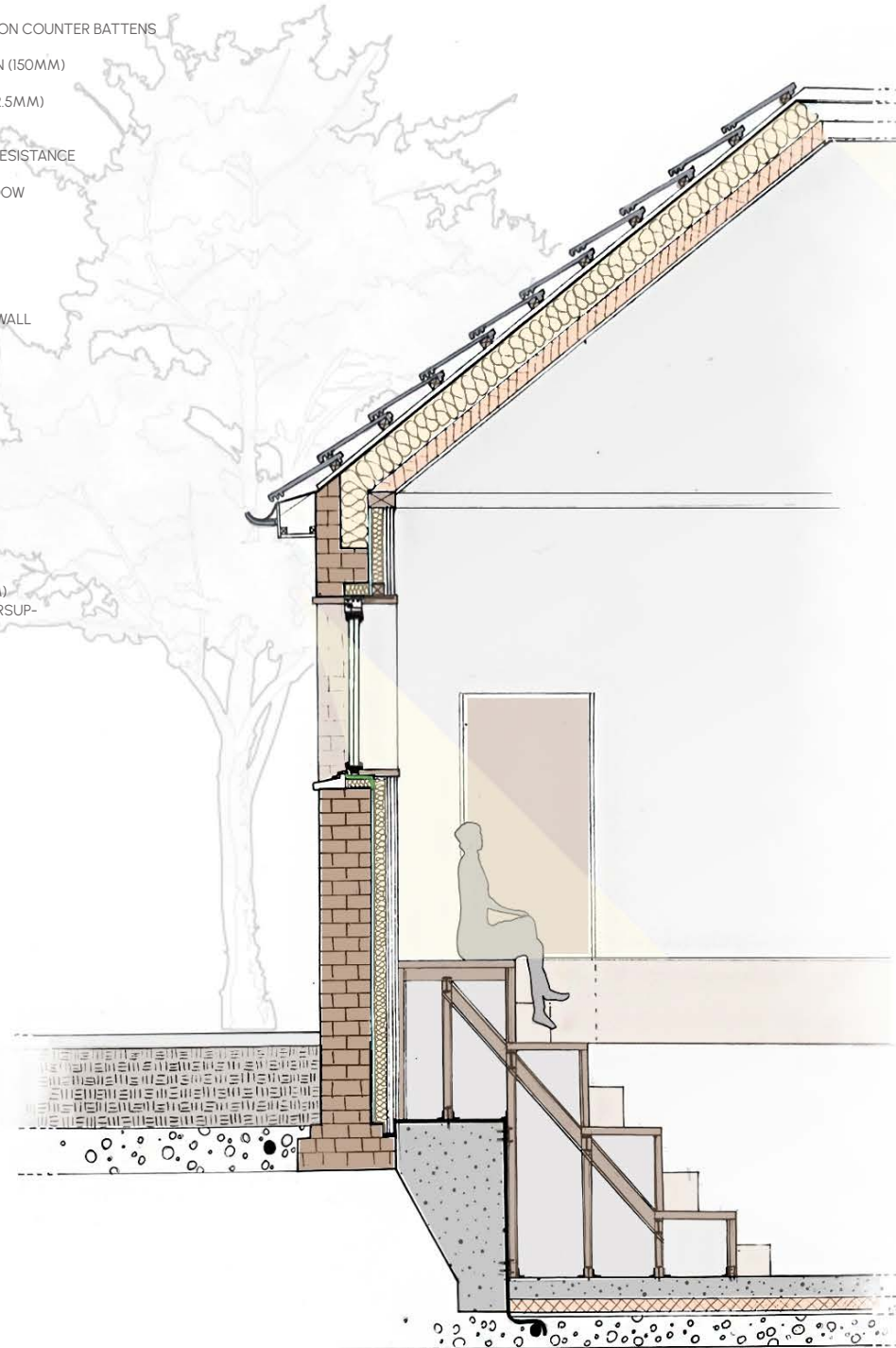
INSULATION UNDER RAFTERS (62.5MM)
VAPOUR CONTROL LAYER
PLASTERBOARD (12.5MM)
WALL PLATE WITH 30MINS FIRE RESISTANCE

SEALANT TO THE BACK OF WINDOW
DOUBLE GLAZED GLASS
SILICONE SEALANT
AIR TIGHTNESS TAPE
GALVANIZED WINDOW STRAPS
CILL

ORIGINAL FLEMISH BRICKWORK WALL
AIR GAP (20-50MM)
NATURAL INSULATION (95MM)
VAPOUR CONTROL LAYER
PLYWOOD (12MM)
PLASTERBOARD (12MM)
WATERPROOF MEMBRANE

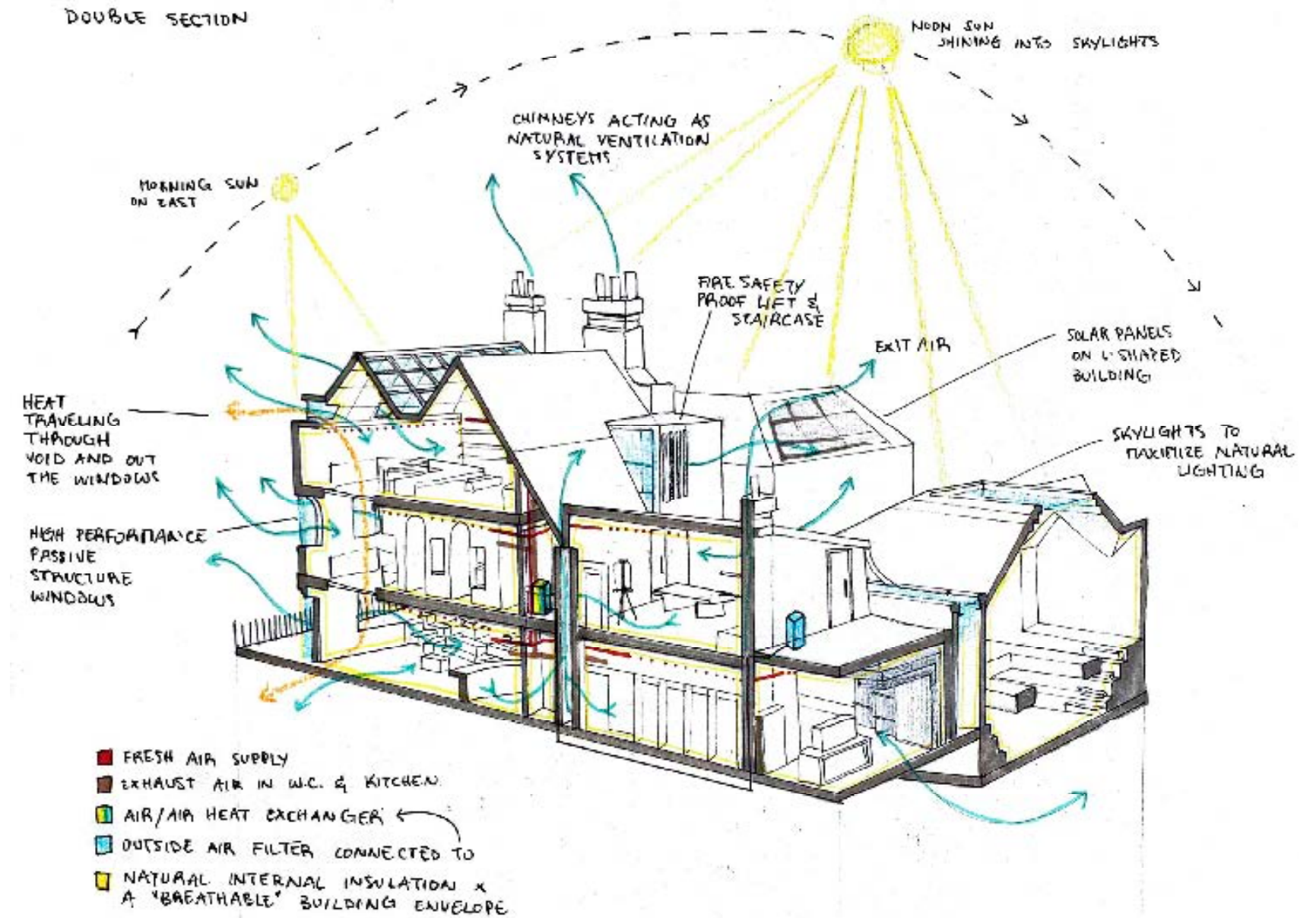
CONCRETE BENCH FOOTING
CONCRETE FLOOR SLAB
RIGID INSULATION
DPM
GRAVEL
NEW DRAINAGE SYSTEM

TIMBER STEPS, Z SECTION (3MM)
TIMBER FEET BOLTED TO TIMBERSUP-
PORT RAKER FRAME (40X40X25)



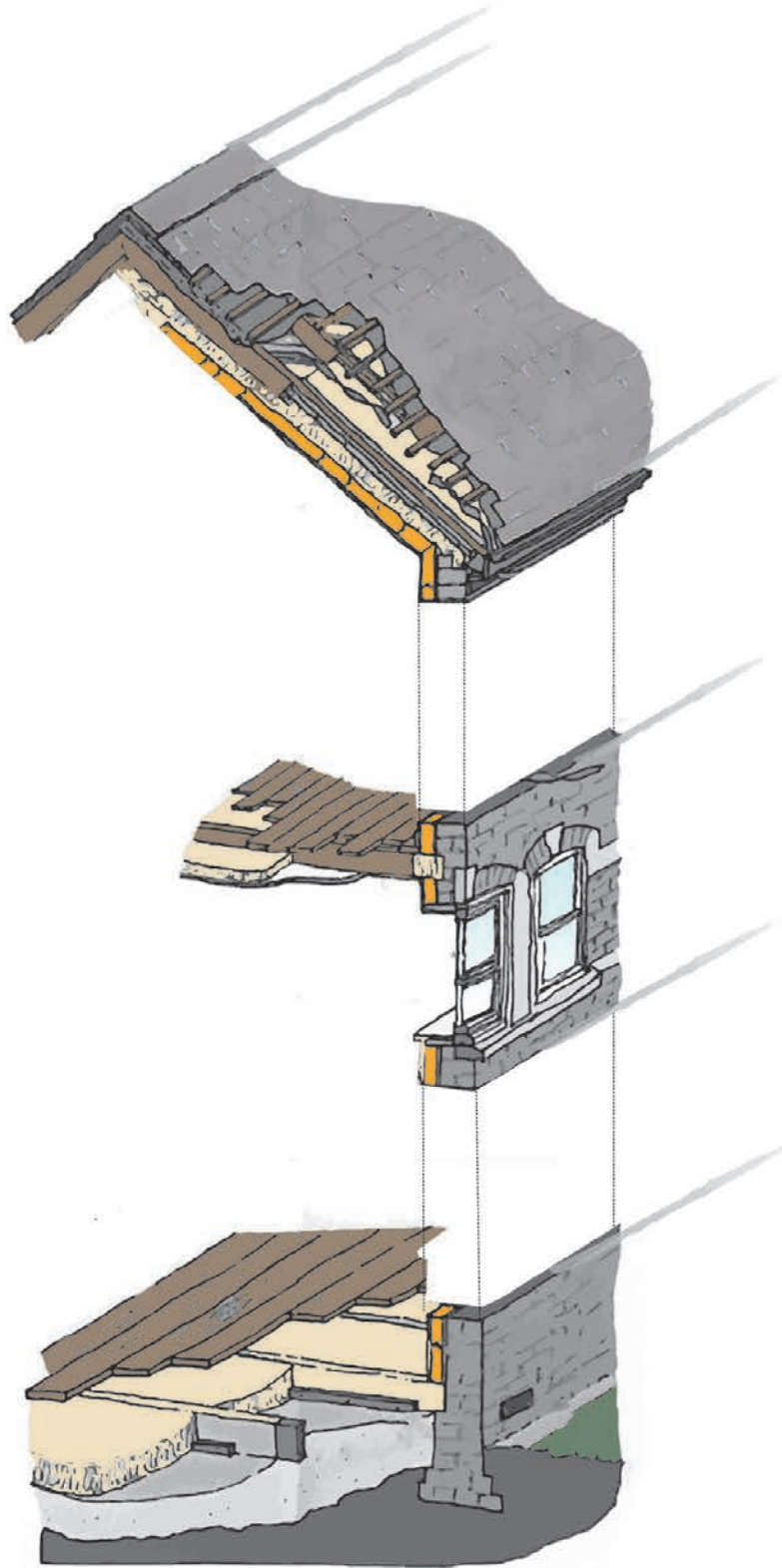
Environmental STRATEGY

Hand Sketch showing a double section through the NW part of the CCC, looking into ventilation, lighting, heating, and circular economy strategies



Technical Construction STRATEGIES

Diagrams and Sketches showing the technical resolutions of various sections of the structure, focusing on passive, ecological techniques that are sensitive towards historical buildings



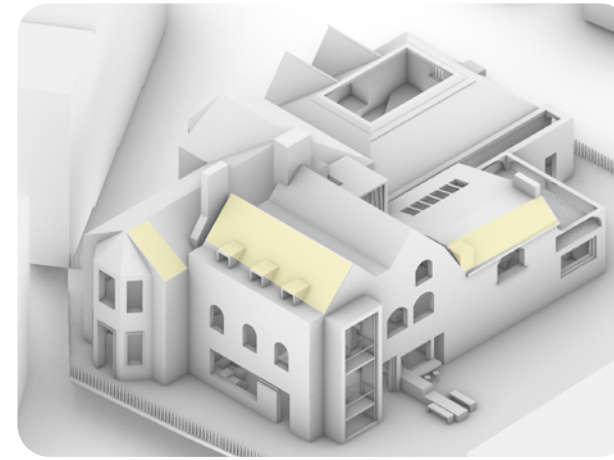
Continuous layer of natural insulation with no thermal bridges
Breathable finishes to interior
Flexible insulation between timber joists and studs

Replace tiles on pitched roof(s) and insulate between and over rafters if possible
50mm of air space between insulation and roofing for ventilation

Planning permission required for external insulation, so internal insulation will be used. internal is better for thermal comfort as long as constructed well

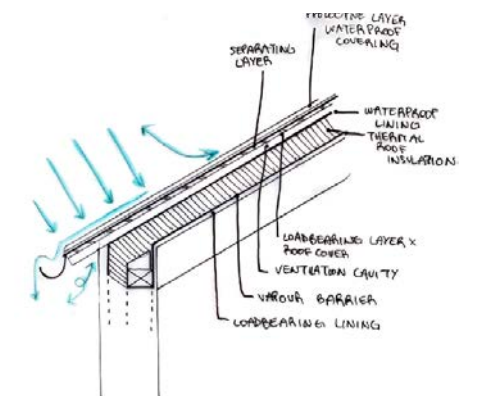
Insulation between joists of flooring from below and add vapour open airtight membrane rigid insulation over stable existing floors

Replace old windows and doors with double or triple glazed glass and external solar shading for summer
Install Air Source Heat Pump as a renewable heating system



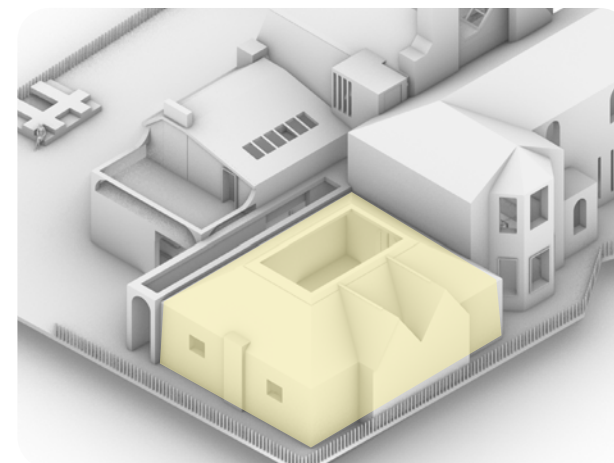
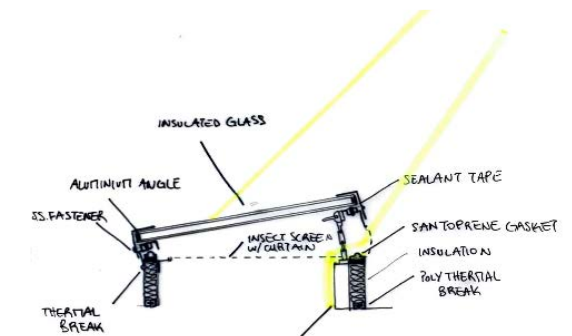
NE view

Roof detail throughout pitched roofs in the building



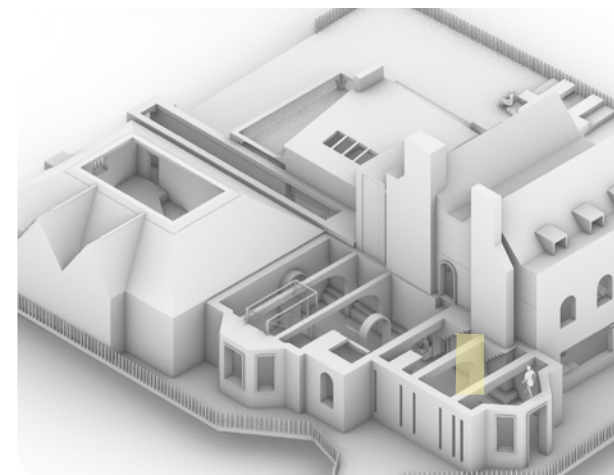
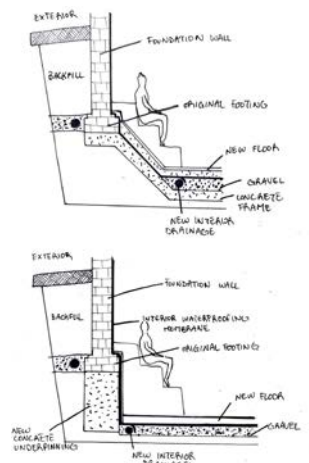
NW view

Manual opening of skylight in artists' studio



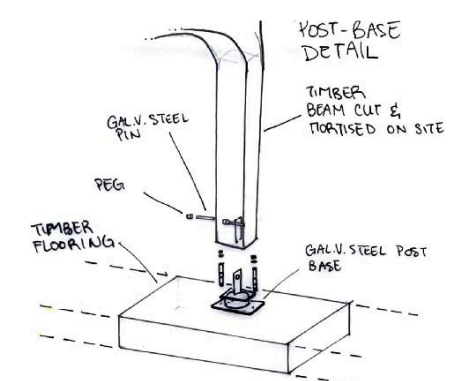
SW view

Underpinning vs. bench footing techniques



SE view

Timber Internal installations detail





Exterior View of the Renovated CCC



Ground Floor | Cafe



Ground Floor | "7 Messengers" Exhibition Room



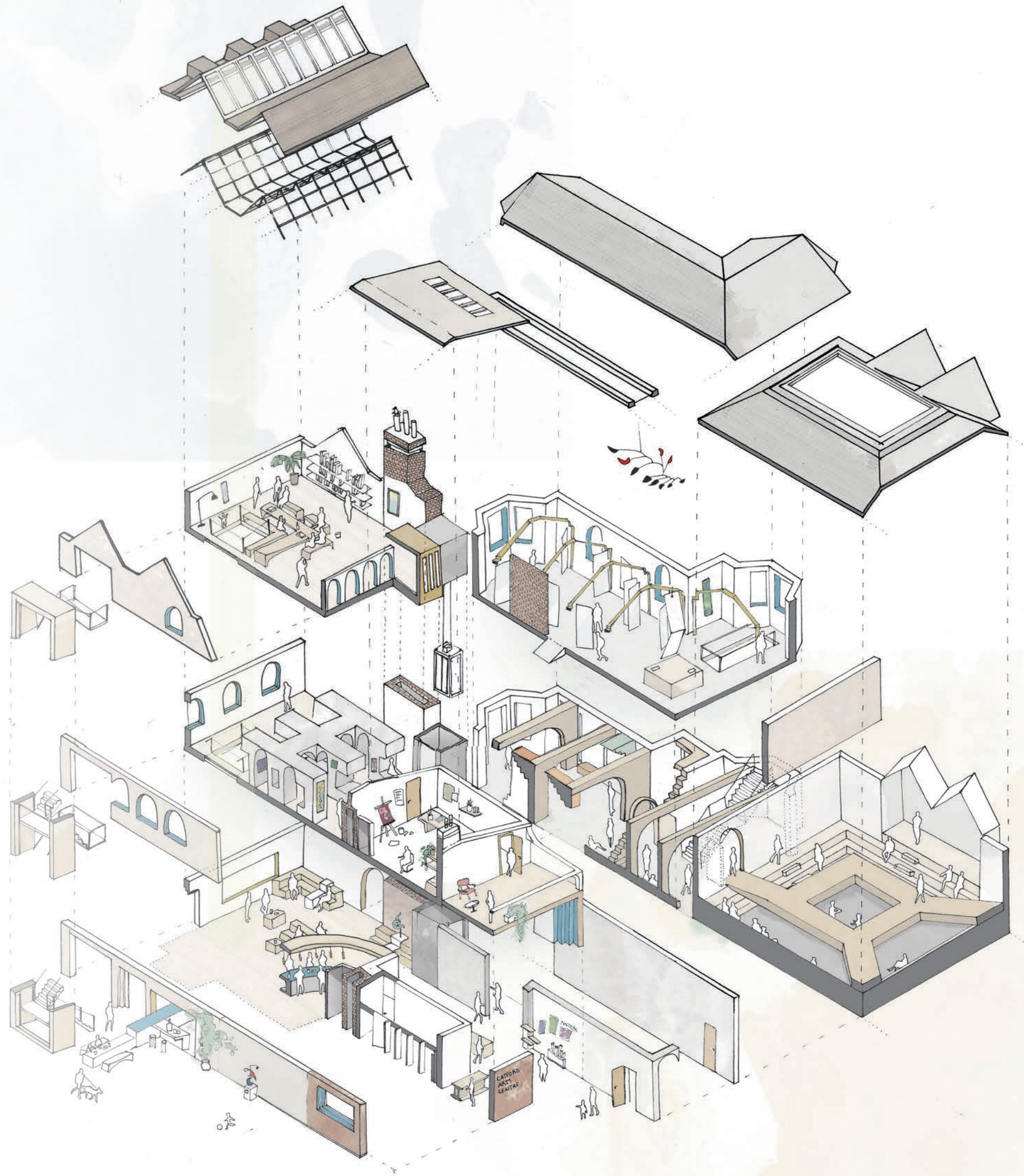
1st Floor | "Superfluous Invitations" Exhibition Room



2nd Floor | "Memory of a Poet" Library and Seminar Room

Exploded Axonometric **Section HAND DRAWING**

Hand drawing that presents an enlarged visual of all the interior and exterior spaces, the interaction between them, and the occupation of rooms. Each area of the renovated structure is making the most of the structural advantage to adapt the interior interventions in the way deemed most fit.



Hand drawing, pen/pencils on paper

1:20 MODEL



This exhibition room, modeled around the story 7 Messengers, explores the human journey into the unknown, balancing discovery with appreciation for the past. Inspired by M.C. Escher, my use of arches and "fake" staircases invites curiosity, guiding visitors through a slow, unfolding exploration that reflects the story's themes.

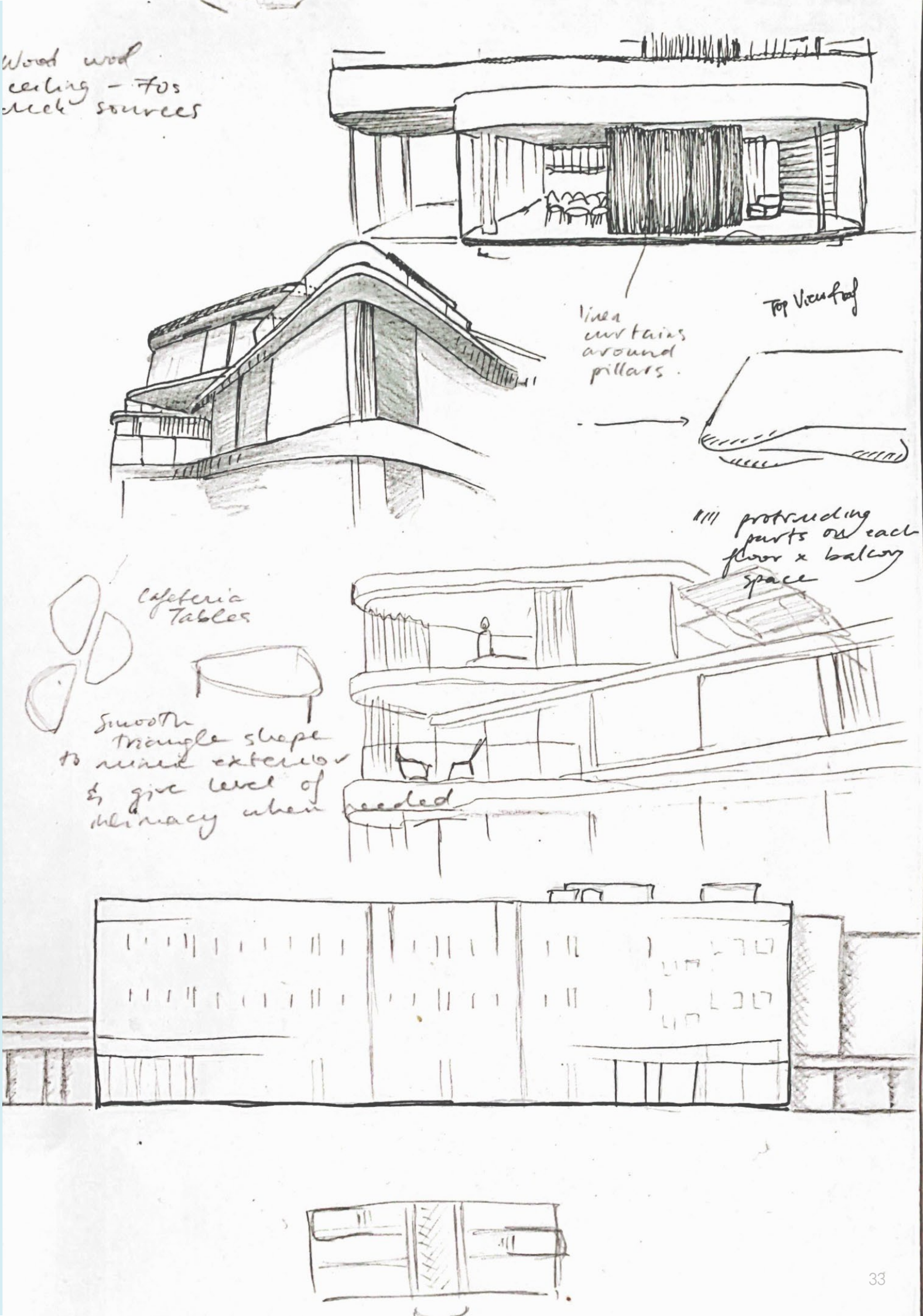
Materials used: balsa wood, foamboard, mountboard, 3D printing for staircase.

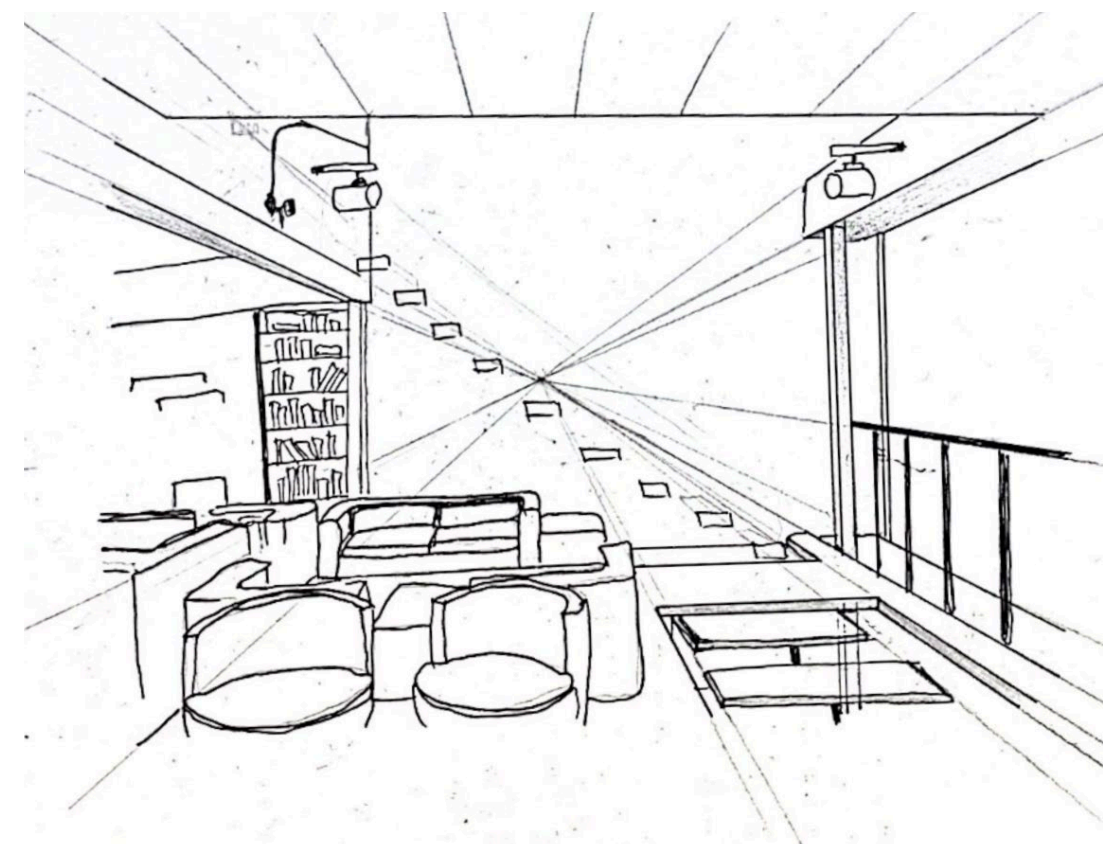
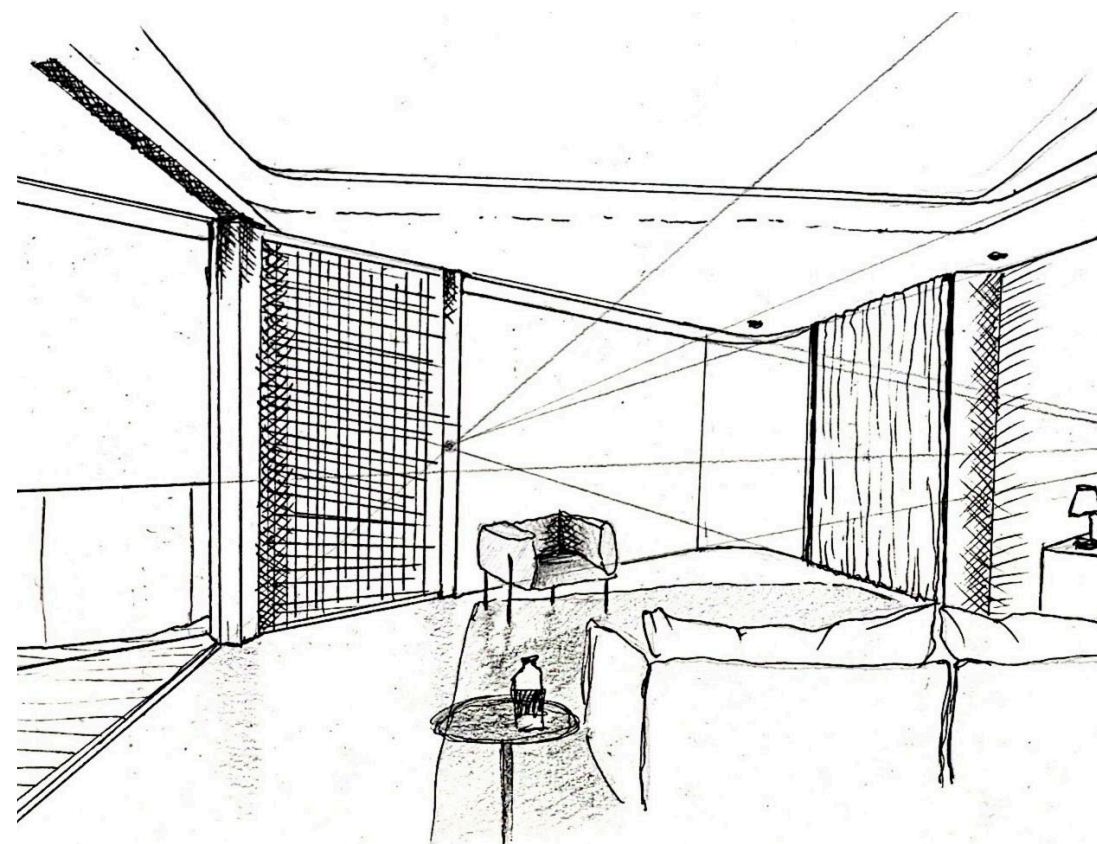
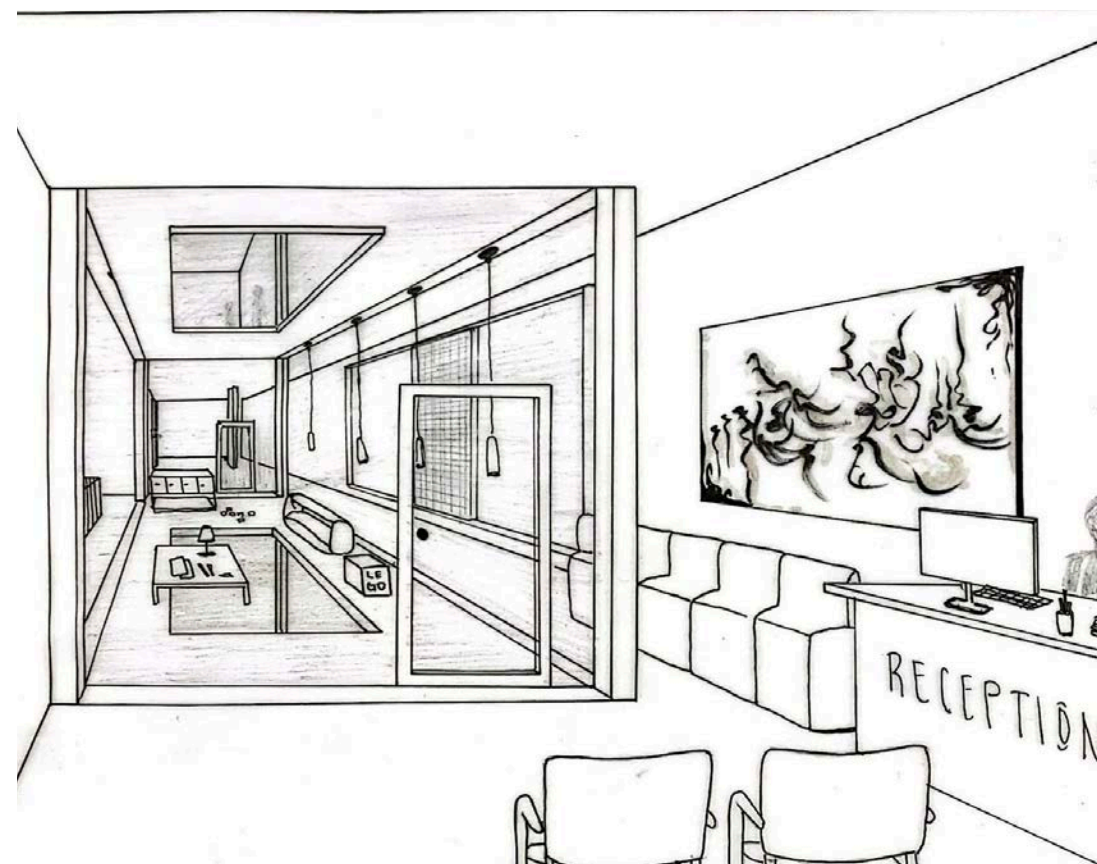
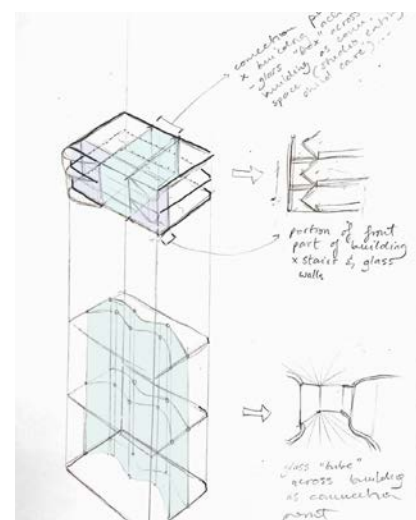
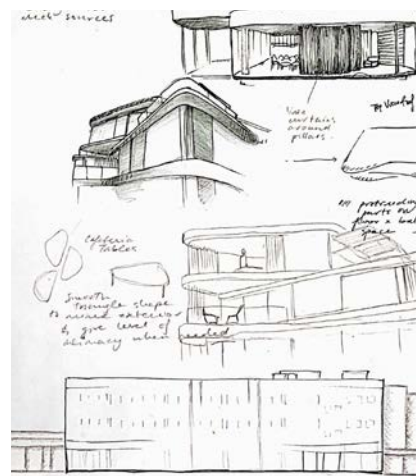


Safe HAVEN

Ridley Road Shopping Centre Refurbishment

For this project I repurposed the Ridley road shopping centre into a cafeteria and clinic. The idea stemmed from a close analysis of the area and its needs, creating an accessible primary care. The final objective was to create a safe space, a place where time slows down in contrast to the relentless vitality of Ridley Road market. A "Safe Haven", therefore, for everyone: children, young people, and everyone else.



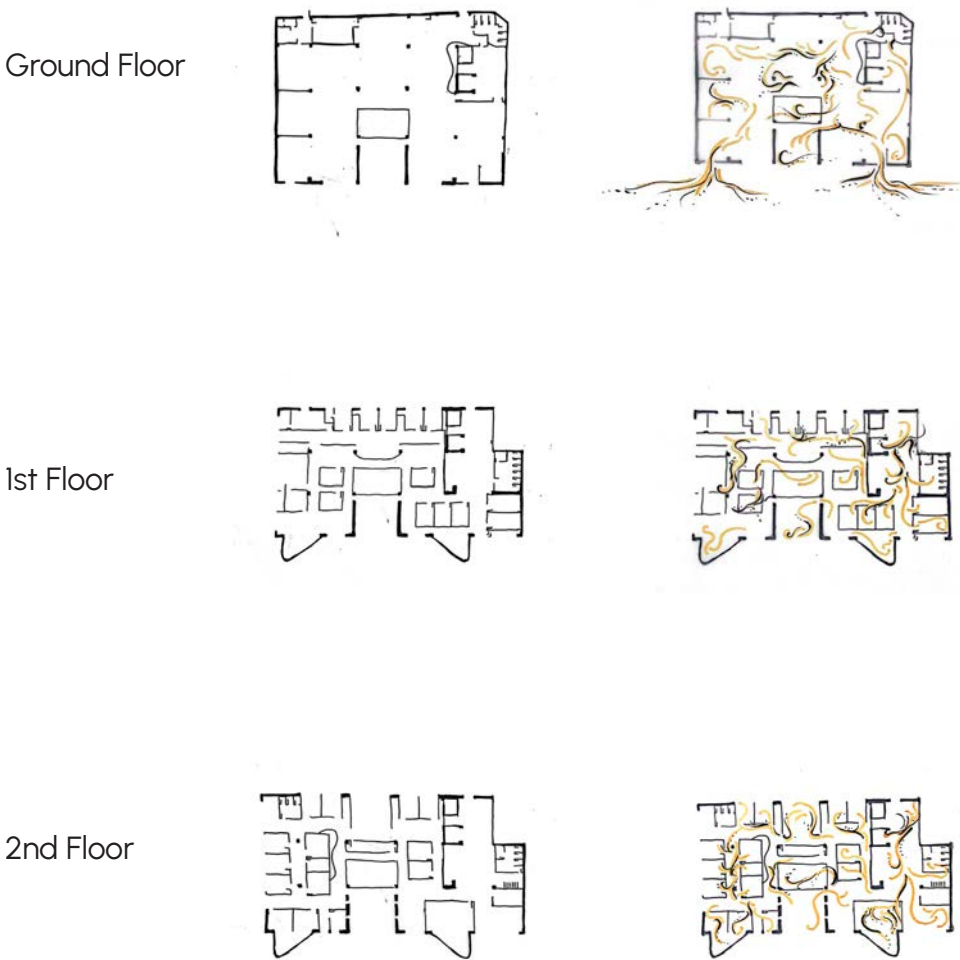


Bottom Right - Initial interior views

Top Left - Sketches focusing on color scheme for the child care area and the appearance of the proposed structure, exploring the strategic contrast between the existing, sharp geometric shapes of the structure and the addition of more fluid shapes to accommodate the clients' needs.

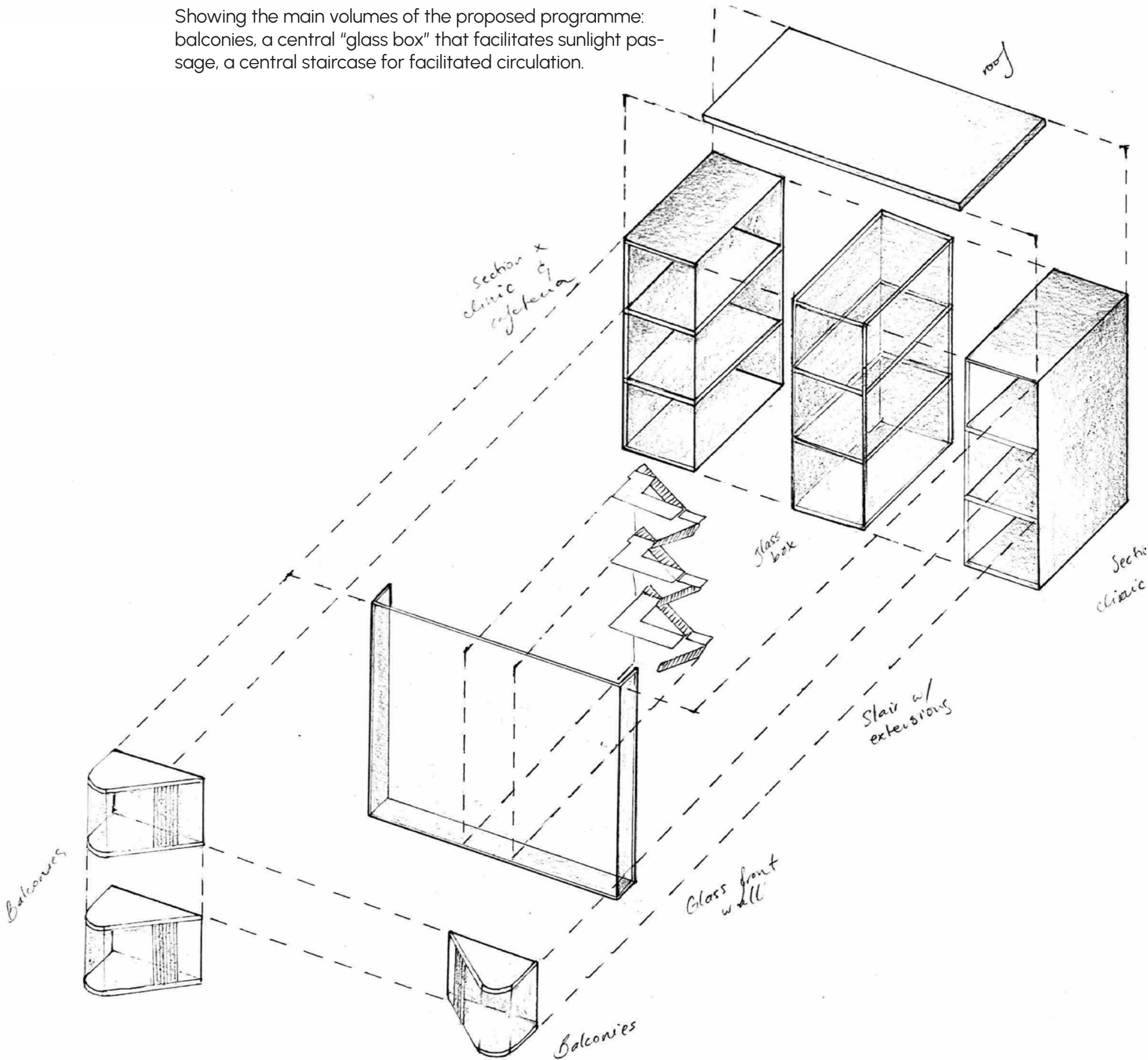
Circulation: DULLING THE LINE BETWEEN PUBLIC & PRIVATE SPACES

These sketches represent an initial first concept sketching of the floor plans with focus on the idea of open floor space.



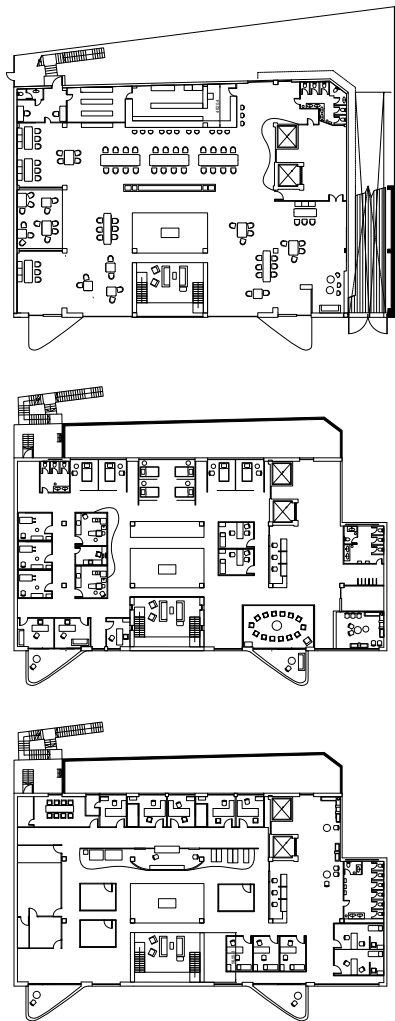
Axonometric DRAWING

Showing the main volumes of the proposed programme: balconies, a central "glass box" that facilitates sunlight pas-sage, a central staircase for facilitated circulation.



Construction Section Detail: FRONT FACADE & BALCONIES

- Floor Plans
3 floors with:
- Reception
 - Waiting area
 - Child care area
 - Toilets
 - Consulting rooms
 - Therapy rooms
 - Women's health rooms
 - Treatment rooms
 - Exam rooms
 - Cafeteria

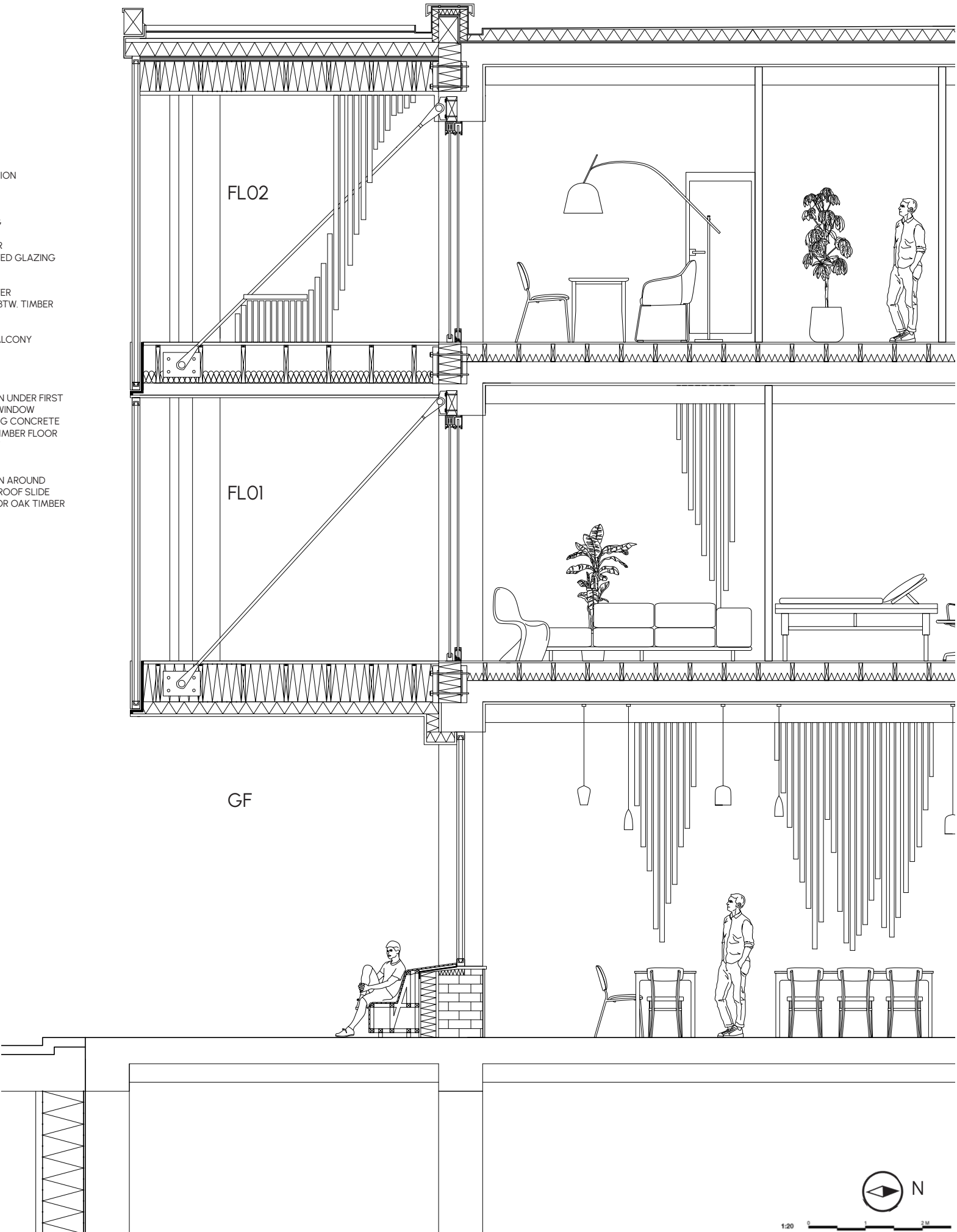


- SEDUM ROOF ON TOP BALCONIES
- MINERAL FIBRE THERMAL INSULATION
- AERATION LAYER
- MOISTURE RETENTION LAYER
- FILTER FABRIC
- ENGINEERED SOIL WITH PLANTING
- DRAINAGE AND ROOT BARRIER LAYER
- INSULATED TEMPERED GLASS, CURVED GLAZING
- BALCONY BASE
- MINERAL BASED EXTERNAL PLASTER
- FIBERGLASS SOUND INSULATION BTW. TIMBER
- JOISTS
- TIMBER DECKING
- STEEL CABLE FOR CANTILEVER BALCONY
- SUPPORT
- SLIDING GLASS DOORS
- MINERAL FIBRE THERMAL INSULATION UNDER FIRST
- BALCONY UNTIL GROUND FLOOR WINDOW
- INSULATION LAYER BTW. PRE EXISTING CONCRETE
- INTERNAL FLOOR AND BALCONY TIMBER FLOOR
- WITH BOLTS FOR SUPPORT
- PLASTERBOARD LINING
- MINERAL FIBRE THERMAL INSULATION AROUND
- EXISTING BRICK WALL WITH WATERPROOF SLIDE
- BTW. WALL AND EXTENDING EXTERIOR OAK TIMBER
- BENCHES

- Materiality:
- Double glazed glass
 - Existing concrete floor with insulation, linoleum flooring in clinic spaces, timber flooring in cafeteria
 - Mineral fibre thermal insulation and XPS insulation to also aid in noise reduction
 - Design details such as fluid geometric timber walls to relax patients and fabrics strategically used to cover windows



Rhino - Make 2D, then in-
software detailing



1:20 MODEL



This model represents two therapy rooms sharing a balcony on the top floor. Soft colors and timber elements create a sense of security and connection to nature. The curved balcony softens the building's geometry, offering a calm retreat from the busy market below. This space embodies the project's purpose: providing a public service and a safe haven.

Materials used: balsa wood sheets, mountboard, cardboard, card, metal wire.

